Don’t Judge Citizens for Changing Their Opinions

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Abstract

Citizens often change their minds about policy. Scholars take this instability as evidence that citizens’ opinions are not “meaningful”—a failure of competence that leaves democracy without preferences to represent. Yet scholars rarely define the term, and direct tests of whether stability indicates meaningfulness are almost entirely absent. This article addresses both gaps. Drawing on a deep tradition in public opinion research, I define an opinion as meaningful when it is consistent with a citizen’s fundamental goals, or “values.” Using panel data from three countries ($n > 29,000$), I show that value-consistent opinions are only slightly more stable than value-inconsistent ones. Consequently, stable opinions are, at most, six percentage points more likely to be value-consistent. A dominant indictment of citizen competence and democratic representation—that opinion instability reveals an absence of meaningful opinions—thus rests on an empirical premise that, in its first large-scale test, finds little support.

Can citizens' policy opinions offer meaningful guidance to policymakers? Many political scientists fear that the answer is no. While citizens are often willing to voice opinions about public policies, these opinions frequently change over time. Since Converse (1964), scholars have read such instability as evidence that many citizens' opinions are superficial or, at least, unreliable indicators of what citizens actually value (Zaller 1992). Other work makes the reverse inference, treating stable opinions as meaningful (Ansolabehere, Rodden and Snyder 2008; Vivyan, Lauderdale and Hanretty 2026). And because most citizens' opinions are unstable on most issues, the implication is that most policy opinions are meaningless.[1]

This argument casts a shadow over citizen competence and representation, which presupposes that citizens have meaningful opinions to which governments can and should respond. Citizens vote directly on consequential policy referendums (e.g., Brexit), and their policy opinions strongly shape the candidates they support (Ansolabehere and Kuriwaki 2022; Mummolo, Peterson and Westwood 2021). If those opinions do not reflect what citizens actually value, citizens risk voting for policies at odds with their own goals (Lau and Redlawsk 1997), elected officials are left without guidance on what policies to implement (Butler and Nickerson 2011), and elections cannot discipline governments to serve citizens' ends (Achen and Bartels 2017). As Achen (1975) warned, if citizens lack meaningful policy opinions, "democratic theory loses its starting point" (1220).

Yet, the idea that an opinion's stability indicates its meaningfulness rests on two claims that have gone largely unexamined. The first is conceptual: that "meaningful" refers to some

[1] Claude Fable 5 (Anthropic), accessed via the Claude Code application between July 26 and August 10, 2026, was used to copyedit this article and to debug the replication code. All output was reviewed and edited by the author.

definite property of opinions that democratic representation requires. However, scholars have defined the term rarely and inconsistently. The second is empirical: that stability actually tracks this property. Yet, almost no study has tested this assumption directly. Unless both claims can be substantiated, opinion instability cannot prove that citizens are incompetent or that representation lacks its starting point. This article examines both claims.

First, I propose an explicit, minimalist definition of a "meaningful" opinion. Drawing on a deep tradition in public opinion research, I treat a policy opinion as representationally meaningful when it is consistent with the fundamental goals that guide citizens' judgments—what I call "values" (Rokeach 1973; Schwartz et al. 2012). This is the form of "meaningfulness" most relevant to representation: An opinion cannot steer government toward what a citizen wants if it points away from those goals.

Second, I test whether value-consistent opinions are more stable over time. Within panel datasets from Germany, the Netherlands, and the United States ($n > 29,000$), I identify pairs of basic values and policy issues wherein prior literature consistently ties the value (e.g., concern for others) to a particular opinion (e.g., support for welfare). Value-consistent opinions, I find, change nearly as much as value-inconsistent ones. Knowing an opinion is stable raises the probability that it is value-consistent by no more than six percentage points.

If stability cannot discriminate between value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions, then decades of research on opinion stability tell us less about citizen competence and democratic representation than is often assumed. My results also suggest we need new tools for evaluating citizens' opinions. Rather than asking *how often* citizens' opinions change, we should ask *what* changes them and *why*.

Why Worry About Opinion Stability?

For six decades, political scientists have wrestled with a seemingly simple question: How often do citizens change their minds about policy issues? This debate began with Converse (1964), who provocatively suggested that all but a "hard core" of the public hold meaningless opinions that vacillate over time. Achen (1975) retorted that much of the apparent change reflects measurement error from ambiguous survey questions. Wave after wave of researchers—armed with better data, newer models, and softer assumptions—has since tried to disentangle true opinion change from statistical noise, each arriving at a different balance (Ansolabehere, Rodden and Snyder 2008; Erikson 1979; Feldman 1989; Lauderdale, Hanretty and Vivyan 2018).

But why has opinion stability received so much attention? It is not because stability is important in itself: Stability matters because it is taken to signal whether citizens' policy opinions are *meaningful*.[2]

The connection between stability and "meaningfulness" has been read in two ways. The first reading treats *instability* as evidence *against* meaningful opinion. Converse (1964) argued that a fluctuating policy opinion is "*prima facie* evidence" (47) that the opinion is

[2]That said, stability may matter for political influence: An opinion can shape behavior only to the extent it persists (Luttrell and Togans 2021), and durable opinions may be easier to represent (Krosnick 1988, 253). Yet, aggregate support for a policy—the quantity policymakers attend to—is usually stable even when individual opinions are not (Page and Shapiro 1992), and we should want citizens to change their opinions when confronted with relevant information (Delli Carpini and Keeter 1996, 231–235).

unconstrained by “some superordinate value or posture toward man and society” (7). Unstable opinions, in this reading, represent “non-attitudes” invented on the spot to satisfy researchers (Converse 1964) or clumsy amalgamations of whatever considerations happened to be top-of-mind when a question was asked (Zaller 1992). Because ordinary citizens’ opinions lack such constraint, Converse (1964) claimed, only 65% manage to “locate themselves even on the same side of a controversy” after two years. By contrast, he expected that 90% of legislators, whose opinions presumably are so constrained, would hold the same stance (45).

The second reading, more common in later work, treats *stability* as evidence *for* meaningful opinion. As Vivyan, Lauderdale and Hanretty (2026) write, “a respondent is considered more likely to have a well-formed opinion on an issue to the extent that their stated opinion on that issue remains consistent” across panel waves (23). Similarly, Freeder, Lenz and Turney (2019) ask “[w]hat share of citizens hold meaningful views about public policy?” (274) and answer by counting stable opinions (288).

Thus, our fixation on opinion stability is animated by concerns about citizen competence and, ultimately, democratic representation (Price and Neijens 1997). The benchmark of empirical research on representation is “the continuing responsiveness of the government to the preferences of its citizens” (Dahl 1971, 1; Druckman 2014)—a standard that presupposes citizens hold meaningful preferences to which government can respond (Sabl 2015). Pervasive opinion instability seems to dissolve the presupposition: If citizens’ survey responses wander at random, there are seemingly no preferences for elected officials to represent and no fixed standard by which voters can hold politicians accountable (Freeder, Lenz and Turney 2019). As Inglehart (1985) put it: “[I]f most citizens don’t really have any coherent or stable preferences about major political issues, why should political decision makers take them into account? Indeed, how could they?" (97).

The stability debate, in short, has never been about stability for its own sake: Stability is scrutinized as a diagnostic of meaningfulness. Whether it can bear this weight depends on the two claims identified above: that "meaningful" has a fixed referent, and that stability tracks it. The next two sections take each in turn.

What Is a Meaningful Opinion?

For all its influence, the reasoning above leans on a term—"meaningful" opinions—that the literature defines rarely and inconsistently. The term is used interchangeably with others, such as "real," "genuine," "high-quality," and "sophisticated." Even work that treats opinion quality systematically tends to enumerate criteria without specifying how they relate. For instance, Price and Neijens (1997) catalog "[s]tability, lack of volatility" and "[c]onsistency with values, other opinions" among many other quality criteria (346), concede that several are contradictory, and propose "no immediate solution to this problem" (355).

This slippage is consequential because the criteria are conceptually and empirically distinct (Conner, Wilding and Norman 2022; Howe and Krosnick 2017). To some, "meaningful" denotes bare authenticity: Some real, nonrandom evaluation stands behind the survey response. To others, it bundles further virtues: The opinion is well-informed (Delli Carpini and Keeter 1996), coherently connected to other beliefs (Converse 1964), and resistant to arbitrary influence (Druckman 2001). This leaves unclear what stability is supposed to certify.

This article therefore fixes a referent. Common to scholars' varied uses of "meaningful" is a concern about democratic representation. I thus use the term in a narrow, *representational* sense: A policy opinion is representationally meaningful when it is consistent with the citizen's fundamental goals—what I will call "values" (Rokeach 1973; Schwartz et al. 2012).[3] Values specify the ends that citizens wish to achieve; public policies are possible means to those ends. A representationally meaningful opinion, then, selects the option that better advances a citizen's ends. Citizens can steer governments toward such policies only if their expressed opinions point toward, rather than away from, their values (Ansolabehere, Rodden and Snyder 2008; Mummolo, Peterson and Westwood 2021).

Table 1: Proposed Links Between Value Grounding and Stability

Quote	**Source**
"Another likely reason for the enhanced stability of important policy attitudes is linkage between these attitudes and core values."	Krosnick (1990, 68)
"[G]eneral orientations—under most conditions—should be fairly stable. And if these beliefs structure more specific attitudes… orientations like militarism may provide the very stabilizing 'anchors' to policy attitudes…"	Peffley and Hurwitz (1993, 63)
"[T]he ease with which [citizens] can be blown from one side of an issue to the other suggests that the positions they take are far from securely anchored in underlying, enduring principles."	Sniderman and Theriault (2004, 113–114)
"[T]he more people moralize an attitude, the less they tend to change that attitude in response to persuasive arguments…"	Luttrell and Togans (2021, 552)
"Central components of belief systems should have a greater impact on other components, and therefore, these central components should keep other attitudes stable."	Turner-Zwinkels and Brandt (2023, 2)

[3]The definition of "values" is deliberately broad: A value can be a moral commitment, such as concern for the welfare of others, but it need not be. In the theory of values introduced below, the self-interested desire to accumulate resources is also a value (Schwartz 2012).

This definition is not plucked from thin air. Converse (1964) himself was interested in opinions constrained by superordinate values, and the most influential operationalizations of opinion quality are largely derivative of value-consistency (Sniderman and Bullock 2004, 337). The expectation that policy opinions should correlate with one another is only sensible if these opinions flow from the same superordinate value (Peffley and Hurwitz 1985). Political knowledge matters not in itself but because, without it, citizens cannot "connect their values with concrete matters of politics" (Delli Carpini and Keeter 1996, 229). Most importantly, meaningful opinions are expected to persist because *values* persist: Values are relatively stable over time (Milfont, Milojev and Sibley 2016; Vecchione et al. 2020; Zaller 1992), so the opinions anchored to them should be stable too. Table 1 shows how deeply the connection between value-consistency and stability runs in the literature.

Indeed, the idea that values organize policy opinions anchors its own sizable literature, which finds that political values of many kinds predict policy opinions in their respective domains (for a review, see Feldman 2003). Beliefs about equality and economic individualism structure social welfare opinions (Feldman 1988), general postures like militarism anchor foreign policy attitudes (Peffley and Hurwitz 1993), and moral traditionalism organizes positions on cultural controversies (Goren 2012). More recent work grounds policy opinions in a small set of basic human values (Enke, Rodríguez-Padilla and Zimmermann 2022; Goren et al. 2016)—a move I return to below.

To be sure, opinions may also be constrained in other ways—e.g., through elite-defined packages associated with political parties or other social groups (Converse 1964; Elder and O'Brian 2022; Freeder, Lenz and Turney 2019). Such "social" constraint can also produce opinion stability, but its implications for democratic representation are ambiguous: A socially constrained opinion need not advance the citizen's own fundamental goals. Indeed, a large literature laments how readily parties sway citizens to endorse or oppose policies, whatever their substance (for a review, see Bullock 2020).

Value-consistency, in short, is the criterion relevant to the representational conception of "meaningfulness," for which the others—stability included—are proxies. I hereafter replace the term "meaningful" with "value-consistent." The remaining question is empirical: Does stability track value-consistency?

Does Opinion Stability Signal Value-Consistency?

If stability is a sound diagnostic of value-consistency, then research on opinion stability doubles as evidence about citizen competence and democratic representation: Counting stable opinions would reveal how many citizens form opinions competently and how many value-consistent preferences there are for government to respond to. Whether stability is a sound diagnostic, however, is the second unexamined claim.

Despite six decades of research connecting value-consistency to opinion stability, direct evidence on whether stability tracks value-consistency is scarce. To my knowledge, only one study has examined the relationship (Peffley and Hurwitz 1993). That study, however, surveyed just 301 residents of one U.S. city, tracking only foreign policy attitudes over one year. It also focused on political values, which, as I discuss later, may not be exogenous to citizens' partisanship or policy opinions (Goren 2005; Goren, Federico and Kittilson 2009).

The remaining evidence for the consistency-stability link is indirect and mixed. Some studies suggest that politically knowledgeable citizens hold more stable opinions (Converse

2000; Delli Carpini and Keeter 1996; Feldman 1989; Kinder and Kalmoe 2017), while others find little difference (Achen 1975; Ansolabehere, Rodden and Snyder 2008; Erikson 1979). Even where they do, it is unclear *why*. Knowledgeable citizens may be more likely to form value-consistent opinions (Zaller 1992). But the pattern is also compatible with motivated reasoning (Taber and Lodge 2006): They may simply be better at defending their views, regardless of whether those views align with their values.

A separate line of research links opinion stability to self-reported characteristics that might accompany value-consistent opinions. Krosnick (1990) finds that stability correlates positively with issue importance, which he partly attributes to "the linkage between these attitudes and core values" (68). However, when examining a wider range of panel datasets, Leeper (2014) finds this relationship to be small and statistically unreliable. Similarly, Luttrell and Togans (2021) finds a small correlation between stability and moral conviction—i.e., the sense that an opinion reflects one's notions of right and wrong. Yet, moral conviction is distinct from consistency as defined above: People are unreliable reporters of why they hold their opinions (for a review, see Pronin 2009), may misunderstand how their values bear on policy positions (Zaller 1992), or may be influenced by their values without knowing it (Jost 2021). Simply put, an opinion can feel value-based without being value-consistent, and vice versa.

In sum, the assumption that stability can gauge value-consistency rests on surprisingly thin empirical ground. Testing it directly is the goal of the remainder of this article.

Which Opinions Are Value-Consistent?

Assessing whether stability identifies value-consistent opinions first requires identifying which opinions reflect citizens' deeper values. The most direct approach compares citizens' policy positions with their stated values (for a review, see Feldman 2003).[4] For instance, scholars might compare citizens' endorsements of statements such as "It is very important to you to help the people around you" with their opinions on welfare policies (e.g., Goren et al. 2016).

Importantly, political scientists distinguish between political and basic values. *Political* values are narrower, representing "principles and belief assumptions about government, citizenship, and American society" (McCann 1997, 565). For example, "militarism" captures whether a citizen prefers an assertive or accommodating military posture and predicts opinions on issues like defense spending (Peffley and Hurwitz 1993). However, because political values closely resemble the opinions they are meant to explain, some scholars question whether they are distinct from, or exogenous to, policy opinions (Arceneaux et al. 2025). Indeed, citizens' political values are roughly as unstable as their policy opinions (see Appendix G) and just as susceptible to elite influence (Goren 2005; Goren, Federico and Kittilson

[4]Another popular strategy treats opinions as meaningful when they match citizens' self-reported ideology—e.g., when a "conservative" opposes universal healthcare (Kinder and Kalmoe 2017). However, many citizens misunderstand these terms (Ellis and Stimson 2012), so self-labels might not signal much about underlying values. Moreover, ideological self-labels may function less as value summaries than as group identities: Self-identified conservatives (or progressives) are prone to endorse *any* policy labeled conservative (or progressive), regardless of its actual substance (Malka and Lelkes 2010).

2009; Vecchione et al. 2013). Any observed relationship between political values and policy opinions could therefore reflect reverse causation or a common cause like partisanship.

Table 2: Higher-Order Values from Schwartz et al. (2012)

Focus	**Name**	**Description**
Social	Self-Transcendence	Prioritizes the well-being of others, especially those different from themselves, and the natural environment. Expressed through universalism and benevolence.
	Conservation	Emphasizes stability, order, and continuity. Rooted in security, conformity, and tradition, it favors preservation of existing arrangements over rapid change.
Personal	Self-Enhancement	Centers on personal success, status, and control over resources or people. Linked to power and achievement, it advances self-interest.
	Openness to Change	Values independence, novelty, and variety. Grounded in self-direction, stimulation, and hedonism, it encourages exploration and new experiences.

For these reasons, recent work has focused on basic values (e.g., Goren et al. 2016). The most widely used psychological framework (Schwartz et al. 2012) identifies four higher-order values fundamental to people's moral outlooks (see Table 2). Of particular interest to political scientists are the two social values: self-transcendence (concern for the welfare of others, especially those different from oneself) and conservation (desire for physical safety, social order, and the preservation of cultural customs). These values deserve special attention because they dictate how one relates socially to others (Schwartz 2012, 13–14), and citizens tend to form policy opinions based on what they think is best for society as a whole (Sears and Funk 1991).[5]

Basic values also subsume political values, strongly predicting those studied most

[5]Indeed, the effect of "personally focused" values on policy opinions is weaker and less consistent (Goren et al. 2016). Relatedly, self-interest matters mainly when a citizen's personal stakes are obvious and large (Horowitz and Levendusky 2011)—stakes most citizens

in public opinion research—e.g., moral traditionalism, limited government, and equality (Schwartz et al. 2014). They also predict citizens' policy opinions across many domains: Self-transcendence predicts support for economic redistribution, racial equality, immigration, and civil liberties, while conservation predicts support for strict crime policies and military interventions as well as opposition to immigration, racial equality measures, and progressive social policies like gay marriage (for a review, see Appendix B). These relationships are consistent across political cultures, suggesting that values and policy opinions are naturally aligned.

Unlike political values, basic values are plausibly exogenous to both partisanship and policy opinions. They guide people's attitudes and behaviors across all domains of life (Schwartz et al. 2012) and emerge by age eleven, before most political socialization occurs (Collins et al. 2017; Döring et al. 2015). Finally, they are considerably more stable than policy opinions over long periods (Appendix H). In sum, basic values capture the substance of political value constructs while offering stronger guarantees of exogeneity.

Methods

To test whether value-consistent opinions are more stable over time, I use three panel datasets from Germany, the Netherlands, and the United States (summarized in Table 3).[6] These countries have high-quality panels with measures of basic values and many related policy

lack in many policy issues (for a review, see Sears and Funk 1991).

[6]These datasets are the German Longitudinal Election Study (GLES), the Longitudinal Internet Studies for the Social Sciences (LISS) managed by the non-profit research institute Centerdata (Tilburg University, the Netherlands), and the General Social Survey's 2008–2012

opinions. Both the Dutch and U.S. panels use probability-based sampling designs, and the German panel combines quota-matched online samples with probability samples. The countries also differ in potentially important ways: The United States' two major parties may make the mapping from values to opinions relatively simple (Levendusky 2010), while the fragmented multi-party systems of Germany and the Netherlands may complicate that mapping (Brader, Tucker and Duell 2013).

Table 3: Panel Datasets Used in Analysis

Country	**Panelists**	**Policies**	**Waves**	**Period Lengths**	**Panel Length**
Germany	26,682	51	22	$\bar{x} = 1.6$ years; $s = 1.39$	Oct. 2016 – Dec. 2021
Netherlands	1,674	17	10	$\bar{x} = 4.2$ years; $s = 2.57$	Dec. 2012 – Jan. 2024
United States	1,289	77	3	$\bar{x} = 2.6$ years; $s = 0.93$	Apr. 2008 – Aug. 2012

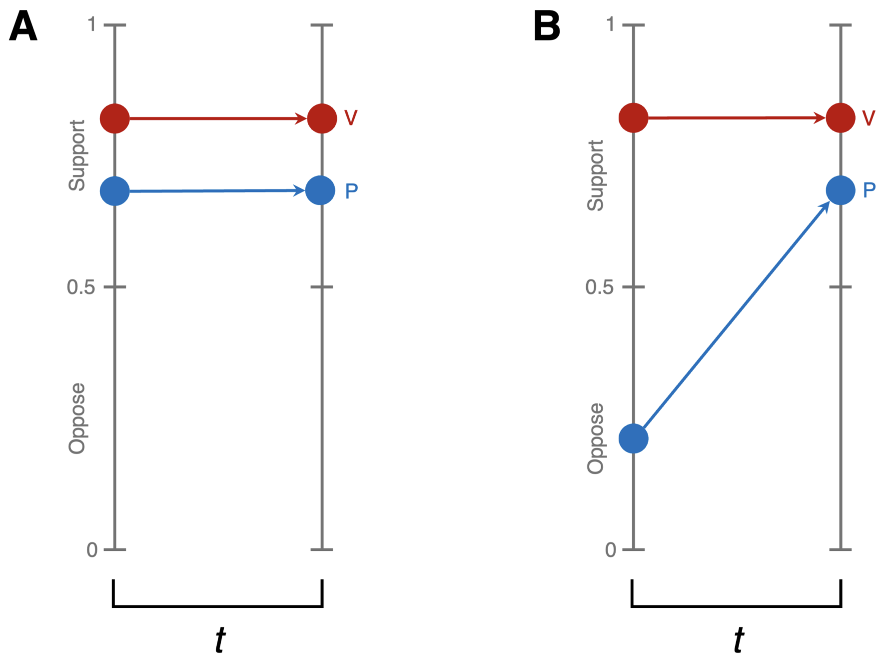
My empirical expectation is straightforward: If stability identifies representationally meaningful opinions, responses consistent with a citizen's values at one wave should change less by the next. Figure 1 illustrates this intuition for some period t, at whose beginning and end we observe a value and a related policy opinion: When the opinion (in blue) is highly consistent with the value (in red), it should change little over t (left panel); when it is less consistent, it should change more (right panel).

To test this intuition, I restructure the panels so each row captures panelist i's opinion on policy p and its relationship to value v over period t, where a period joins two waves (e.g., $t = w_1 \rightarrow w_2$). I then compare the subsequent stability of opinions coded consistent and

panel (GLES 2023; Scherpenzeel and Das 2010; Smith, Marsden and Hout 2013).

inconsistent at the period's start. Observations from panelists, values, policies, and periods are stacked, and fixed effects account for differences across cases.

Figure 1: Empirical Expectations



Note: A stylized depiction of my empirical expectations. Red points represent a panelist's position on a value at the beginning and end of a period, t. Blue points represent their position on a related policy opinion.

Measurement

In each panel, I measure self-transcendence (α = .65–.78) and conservation (α = .59–.73) values by averaging items from a well-validated measure (Schwartz et al. 2001). Question wordings are in the Replication Materials.[7] All three datasets measure each panelist's values once, at the panel's beginning (Germany and the Netherlands) or end (United States).

[7]Replication materials can be found here: https://drive.proton.me/urls/02HTNCCDPG#vHGvRDhFVyyX.

Consistent with past research, I assume that panelists' basic values remain stable throughout the panel (Milfont, Milojev and Sibley 2016; Vecchione et al. 2020).[8] Appendix H validates this assumption with an additional panel dataset, and Appendices I and J confirm that value change does not bias my results.

For ease of interpretation, I measure value-consistency with a binary indicator equal to 1 if a citizen's opinion falls on the value-consistent side of a Likert policy scale and 0 otherwise. For instance, consider this item from the Dutch panel:

> *"It should be made easier to obtain asylum in the Netherlands." (Answers: Fully disagree, disagree, neither agree nor disagree, agree, and fully agree)*

A citizen high in self-transcendence—i.e., someone with strong concern for others' welfare—would be coded as consistent if they supported the policy and inconsistent if they opposed it or were ambivalent. I map self-transcendence and conservation to policy directions based on a systematic review of prior research, considering only relationships that manifest consistently across studies (see Appendix B). Appendix D replicates my analyses using a purely empirical approach—regressing policy opinions on basic values to determine "what goes with what"—with substantively similar results. To ensure comparability, I limit my main analyses to five- to seven-point Likert scales, though Appendix C replicates them with all items.

Importantly, my measure of value-consistency is behavioral: It records whether an opinion falls on the side of an issue that the literature ties to a value, not whether the citizen

[8] In the U.S. panel, political interest is also measured once. I assume it is stable across that panel (Prior 2019).

consciously reasons about the issue from that value. Under the representational definition above, that is the appropriate target, as citizens' opinions are often shaped by their values without their being conscious of this influence (Jost 2021). It also matches how existing tests measure value-consistency: by comparing opinions to measured values (Feldman 2003; Goren et al. 2016), rather than asking citizens to report their reasons for supporting a policy. Even so, several robustness checks assess whether narrowing my sample to conscious value reasoners would change my results: The consistency-stability link is no stronger among respondents for whom these values are most central (Appendix M), for the issues whose cross-sectional value-opinion correlations are strongest (Appendix N), or among the highly educated, politically interested, and (in the German panel) politically knowledgeable (Appendix O).

I code opinion stability two ways, again for ease of interpretation. The first measure equals 1 if a citizen gave the exact same response at both waves of a period and 0 otherwise. This simple measure of test-retest reliability is strict: Even a shift from "fully agree" to "agree" would register as instability, potentially attenuating true differences between value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. The second measure is more lenient: It equals 1 if a citizen remained on the same side of the policy scale across both waves and 0 if they crossed to the other side or became ambivalent.

Statistical Models

To estimate the relationship between opinion stability and value-consistency, for each panel dataset, I run an OLS[9] regression of the following form:

$$OpinionStable_{i,p,t} = \beta_1 * ValueConsistent_{i,p,v,t} + \beta * Traits_{i,t} + \alpha_{p,v} + \delta_{s,p,t} + \epsilon$$

In this model, *OpinionStable* indicates whether panelist i maintained a stable opinion on policy issue p over period t. The primary independent variable, $ValueConsistent$, captures whether that opinion aligned with a specific value v at the start of the period. $Traits$ is a matrix of subject-level controls: a panelist's education, political interest, and age at the beginning of the period, and tendency to acquiesce to all value statements, regardless of their content (Schwartz 1992). This last term minimizes measurement error in $ValueConsistent$ and absorbs any tendency for the acquiescence-prone to hold less stable opinions.

To account for unobserved heterogeneity, the model incorporates two layers of fixed effects. First, "case" fixed effects (α) represent specific value-policy pairings, ensuring the model compares consistency and stability only within a given pairing. Second, "trend" fixed effects (δ) account for the initial stance (s) held on a policy issue (e.g., left, center, or right) during period t. This term allows for the possibility that certain positions are more unstable in general or during specific timeframes. For instance, moderate positions may be more unstable in general, and conservative stances on government intervention may have been more volatile following the 2008 financial crisis. These fixed effects also control for differences in the length of time between panelists' responses.

This approach estimates a single coefficient (β_1) representing the general tendency for

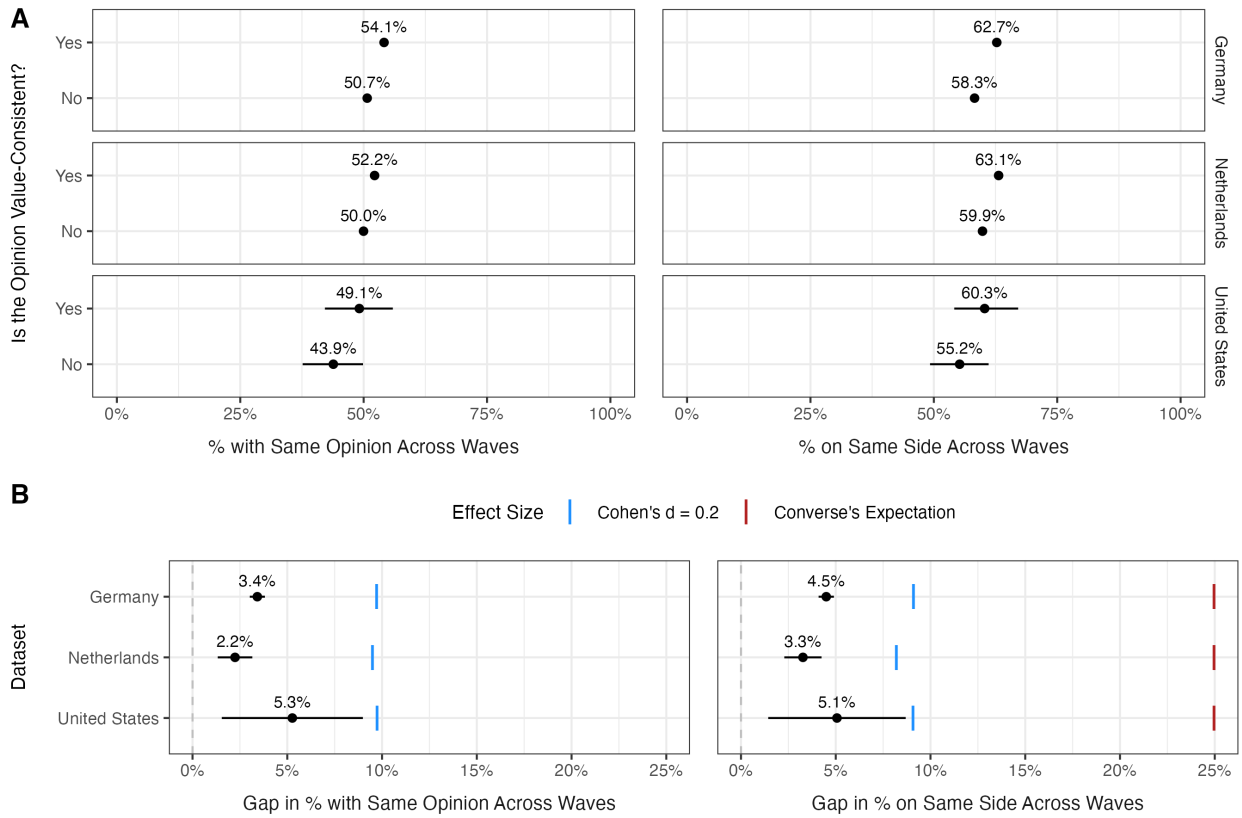
[9]Logit models produce qualitatively similar results (see Appendix A).

value-consistent opinions to be more stable over time. This estimand is diagnostic rather than causal: How well does stability discriminate between measured value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions? Prediction is sufficient to assess a proxy. To be sure, scholars care about stable opinions largely because they are presumed to be causally downstream of citizens' values, and I have taken several steps to strengthen a causal reading: I control for other potential causes of opinion stability and alleviate concerns about reverse causality by ensuring my dependent variable is always measured months after the independent variables. But my question is more pragmatic: Is the best available data consistent with a world in which stability and value-consistency reliably *predict* one another? If not, that alone should caution against treating stability as a proxy for meaningfulness.

Main Results

Sub-figure A of Figure 2 plots the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions—averaged across policy issues, values, and periods. It shows the percentage of respondents who expressed the exact same opinion across waves (left) and the percentage who remained on the same side of a policy scale across waves (right). Sub-figure B plots the gap between these estimates against two benchmarks: a conventionally small effect (*Cohen's* $d \leq 0.2$) and the gap Converse (1964) expected between citizens' and legislators' opinions. The latter is offered as historical context: Though comparing legislators and citizens is unlike comparing value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions within citizens, it is interesting to set the gaps observed here against those that launched the literature.

Figure 2: Relative Stability of Value-Consistent and -Inconsistent Policy Opinions



Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B shows the gap between these estimates alongside Cohen's $d = 0.2$ (blue) and Converse's expected citizen–legislator gap (red). Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

As seen on the left side of Figure 2, panelists in all three panels are only slightly more likely to hold on to value-consistent than -inconsistent opinions. For instance, in the U.S. panel, 43.9% (*95% CI 37.6–49.9*) of panelists who voiced a value-inconsistent opinion at one wave voiced the exact same opinion at the next, compared to 49.1% (*95% CI 42.1–55.9*) of panelists who voiced a value-consistent opinion. This amounts to an increase of roughly five percentage points ($p < .01$). In all three panels, the upper bound of the 95% confidence interval falls below a conventionally small effect size (*Cohen's* $d \leq 0.2$).

The right side of Figure 2 tells a similar story. In the U.S. panel, 55.2% (*95% CI*

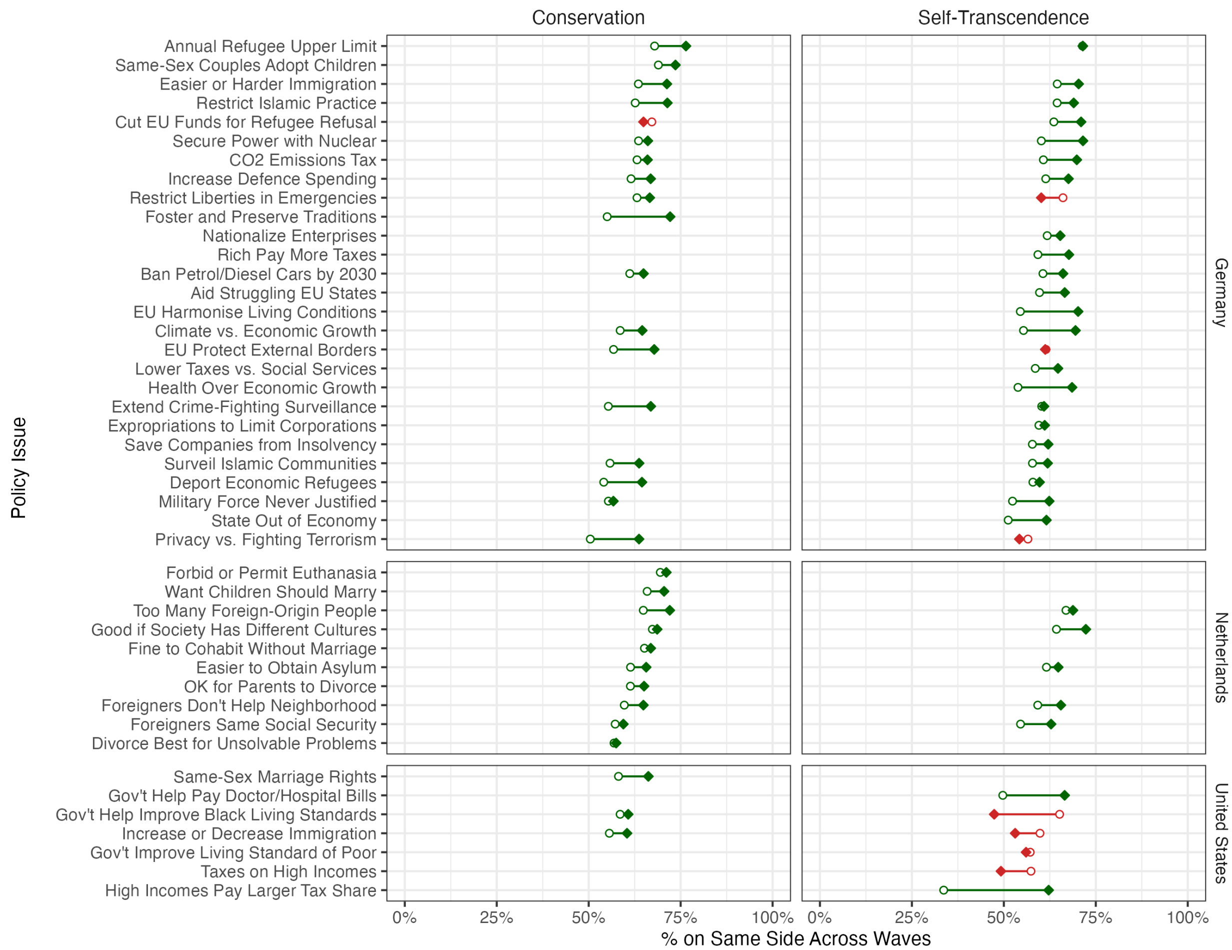
49.2–61.1) of panelists with a value-inconsistent opinion remained on the same side of a policy scale across waves, compared to 60.3% (*95% CI 54.1–67.1*) of those with a value-consistent opinion—a substantively small gap of 5.1 percentage points ($p < .01$). The gap is even smaller in the German and Dutch panels, at 4.5 and 3.3 percentage points respectively ($p < .001$ in both cases). Again, every upper bound falls below the small-effect threshold.

These gaps are roughly one-fifth of the 25-percentage-point difference Converse (1964) expected between ordinary citizens (roughly 65% of whom stayed on the same side of a policy issue over two years) and legislators (about 90%). Importantly, the average period lengths in the panel datasets straddle Converse's two-year benchmark ($\bar{x}_{DE} = 1.6$ years; $\bar{x}_{NL} = 4.2$ years; $\bar{x}_{US} = 2.6$ years). In any case, while longer intervals between waves reduce average opinion stability, they do not widen the gap between value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions (see Appendix F).

But does even this small gap make stability a useful proxy for meaningfulness? A useful proxy should substantially update one's belief about the underlying quantity. Formally, let C denote that an opinion is value-consistent and S denote that it is stable. By Bayes's theorem, $P(C|S) = \frac{P(S|C) \times P(C)}{P(S)}$. Using the observed stability rates and the empirical base rate of value-consistent opinions in each sample, subtracting $P(C|\neg S)$ from this quantity shows that stability shifts the probability that an opinion is value-consistent by no more than six percentage points.[10] In other words, whether an opinion is stable tells us very little about whether it aligns with a citizen's values.

[10] $P(C|S) - P(C|\neg S)$ equals -.03, .01, and .06 in Germany, the Netherlands, and the United States respectively.

Figure 3: Heterogeneity by Case



Note: Predicted stability of value-consistent (filled diamonds) and -inconsistent (open circles) opinions for each case, broken out by value and dataset. Green lines indicate cases where value-consistent opinions are more stable; red lines indicate cases where the relationship reverses. Data weighted to give each panelist and period equal weight.

These averages, however, obscure notable differences across value-policy pairings. Figure 3 plots the predicted stability of value-consistent (filled diamonds) and -inconsistent (open circles) opinions for each case, broken out by value and dataset (see Appendix E for model details).

Two patterns stand out. First, while value-consistent opinions are more stable in most cases, the gap is typically small in the German and Dutch panels: The filled diamonds sit only slightly to the right of the open circles. Second, in a few cases—across both value types—value-consistent opinions are *less* stable than value-inconsistent ones.

The U.S. case-level estimates are more heterogeneous and imprecise: Larger positive and negative estimates partly offset one another rather than producing a uniformly small pattern, likely because the U.S. panel has fewer panelists and waves. In the German and Dutch panels, by contrast, estimates are more precise, and the average effect is small because the case-level effects are themselves small. Either way, opinion stability is a poor proxy for value-consistency: The relationship is too weak to be useful in the German and Dutch panels and too noisy to be reliable in the U.S. panel.

Supplementary Analyses

Small correlations may have various causes. Table 4 summarizes several supplementary analyses, reported in the online appendix, that assess the robustness of my findings to three concerns. None substantively alters the findings.

The first concern is measurement error. Because each panel measures basic values once, I impute them across waves. If values and opinions drift together, the estimated consistency-stability link could be attenuated. Several lines of evidence suggest no such drift. Prior work shows that basic values remain stable for long periods (Milfont, Milojev and Sibley 2016; Vecchione et al. 2016, 2020). In an additional panel with repeated value measures, I confirm that basic values fluctuate little—and far less than most policy opinions (Appendix H). If values shifted, cross-sectional value-policy correlations should weaken as the value measurements grow stale, but no such decay appears (Appendix I). And results are unchanged

Table 4: Supplementary Analyses

Concern	**Analysis**	**OA**
Measurement error may attenuate the diagnostic relationship.	Compare stability of basic values and policy opinions.	H
	Test whether cross-sectional value-policy correlations shift over time.	I
	Subset to participants whose values are least likely to change.	J
	Construct indexes of policy opinions.	K
	Measure value consistency and opinion stability as continuous variables.	L
The selected value may be less relevant in some observations.	Subset to participants who most value self-transcendence (conservation).	M
	Subset to cases with the strongest cross-sectional value-policy correlations.	N
Stability may discriminate better in more sophisticated groups.	Subset to highly educated participants.	O
	Subset to politically interested participants.	O
	Subset to politically knowledgeable participants (Germany).	O

Note: OA refers to the online appendix where an analysis resides.

among middle-aged panelists, whose values are least likely to change (Appendix J; Milfont, Milojev and Sibley 2016).

Additionally, error in the opinion measures does not appear to bias my results: Combining related policy opinions into indexes, which averages away item-level noise (Ansolabehere, Rodden and Snyder 2008), leaves the gap small (Appendix K), as does replacing my binary codings with continuous measures of consistency and stability (Appendix L).

The second concern is that the selected value may be irrelevant in some observations—e.g., because the respondent cares little about it or because the value is too removed from politics. Yet, the consistency-stability link is no stronger among respondents who prioritize the relevant value most (Appendix M) or among those value-policy pairs with the strongest cross-sectional associations (Appendix N).

The third concern is that stability may only discriminate value-consistent from -inconsistent opinions among citizens who are equipped to consciously connect values to concrete policies (Delli Carpini and Keeter 1996; Zaller 1992). It does not: The stability gap remains small among the most educated, the most politically interested, and (in the German panel) the most politically knowledgeable (Appendix O).

Discussion and Conclusion

This article has tested an inference that animates some of the most thoughtful and empirically rigorous work in political science: that an opinion's temporal stability indicates whether it is "meaningful," or capable of guiding public policy toward citizens' goals. Instability troubles scholars because it seems to leave elected officials without preferences to represent, and an opinion cannot steer government toward what a citizen wants unless it is consistent with their most basic goals, or "values."

The test returns a clear answer. Across three countries with very different party systems, value-consistent opinions are only modestly more stable than value-inconsistent ones, and learning that an opinion is stable changes the probability that it is value-consistent by no more than six percentage points—a result that holds across a battery of robustness checks.

How can this be, when values are consistently associated with policy opinions in cross-sectional data (see Appendix B)? The answer, I suggest, is that the assumed link holds only if two conditions jointly obtain: The mapping from values to policy positions must stay fixed, and no force besides values may anchor the opinion. Prior work gives strong reasons to doubt each.

First, value-policy mappings—i.e., which position on a policy issue serves a particular value—can shift, so staying value-consistent can require changing one's opinion. Consider a typical policy item from the German panel:

> *Germany's defence expenditure should be increased over the next few years.*

Individuals higher in conservation values—those who care more about security, among other things—should express greater support for increased defense spending, and studies consistently find this cross-sectional association across countries and contexts (e.g., Rathbun et al. 2016; Schwartz et al. 2014). But it does not follow that value-consistent opinions should remain fixed. Citizens' policy opinions react thermostatically to existing policy (Wlezien 1995): If Germany had recently raised its defense budget substantially, further increases may seem unnecessary even to those who prioritize security. Experimental evidence likewise shows that citizens update preferences when they learn that a policy embodies their values better or worse (Dias 2025). Opinion change, in other words, can reflect principled thinking rather than its absence.

Mappings can also shift because policies engage multiple values and frames change which connection is salient (Nelson, Clawson and Oxley 1997). When a policy conflict pits two values against one another, citizens side with the value they prioritize (Schwartz et al. 2012; Tetlock 1986). Yet, if political discourse highlights only one value, citizens can only ground their opinions in that value: A citizen who supports civil liberties when both freedom and security are salient could oppose the same policy under an exclusively security-focused frame, without changing either value. Media coverage can alter which values citizens bring to bear on policy issues (Brewer 2002), and the framing environment changes over time (Chong and Druckman 2007). And because citizens encounter different information, circumstances, and frames, such remapping need not be uniform: Value-driven opinion changes may offset in the aggregate, leaving little trace in the cross-sectional association between values and policy opinions.

A second potential explanation is rival anchors: Values are not the only force that can hold policy opinions in place (for a review, see Mintz, Valentino and Wayne 2021). Partisan attachments, in particular, may be a powerful source of opinion stability (Elder and O'Brian 2022; Freeder, Lenz and Turney 2019): Citizens often feel emotionally attached to their political parties (Huddy, Mason and Aarøe 2015), and an abundance of experiments shows that they readily adopt or defend policy opinions, regardless of ideological content, when their party endorses them (for a review, see Bullock 2020). And under typical conditions—when citizens agree with their parties (Dalton 2017), parties rarely shift positions (Koedam 2022), and citizens rarely switch parties (Franklin and Jackson 1983)—partisan loyalty should make opinions stable over time, whether or not those opinions reflect the citizen's values. Indeed, as Druckman, Fein and Leeper (2012) write, "[W]hen opinions display stability, it may reflect an underlying bias rather than considered opinions" (445).

Together, the two routes could compress the stability gap from both sides: A moving mapping can reduce stability among initially consistent opinions, while rival anchors can increase stability among initially inconsistent opinions. Which route operates where, however, is a question my panel data are ill-suited to answer. The data do not measure how citizens perceive value-policy alignments, so I cannot estimate the share of opinion changes that follow shifts in perceived mappings. And because party-loyal and value-consistent opinions are often observationally equivalent—and citizens may select parties on the basis of their values—modeling both simultaneously risks post-treatment bias that understates the effects of values. Future work should measure perceived mappings repeatedly, or experimentally manipulate the value-consistency and party-loyalty of competing positions on a non-salient issue and observe how each affects stability.

Other limitations are worth mentioning. The study observes consistency with one selected value at a time—not a person's full value system—so a response coded as inconsistent may in fact advance an unmeasured, competing value. That said, when issues implicate both self-transcendence and conservation values, modeling both simultaneously leaves the consistency-stability gap small (Appendix P). Relatedly, my measure of value-consistency is behavioral, requiring no conscious value reasoning; yet, the consistency-stability link is no stronger where such reasoning is most plausible (Appendices M–O). Finally, each panel measures basic values only once, requiring me to impute values across waves. However, several additional analyses suggest that this choice does not bias my results (Appendices H–J).

These limitations bound my estimates; they do not restore opinion stability as a proxy for value-consistency. The analyses above provide a broad, direct estimate of stability's diagnostic value for basic-value consistency—across three countries, dozens of policy issues, and an array of measurement strategies—where the closest prior person-level test covered one city, one issue domain, and one year (Peffley and Hurwitz 1993).

If we wish to evaluate whether citizens hold value-consistent opinions—and we should, if we care about democratic representation—we need better tools. Rather than asking *how often* citizens' opinions change, a more promising path is to ask whether citizens have the *skills* to form value-consistent opinions (Dias 2025; Druckman 2014)—e.g., whether they respond to specific policy characteristics in ways that reflect their values. This skills-based approach does not require stability to proxy for value-consistency or researchers to anticipate every relevant value. Early evidence suggests citizens do have these skills (Dias 2025), though more work is needed.

For six decades, the instability of citizens' opinions has been read as evidence that citizens are incompetent and that elected officials lack preferences to represent. That reading asked stability to certify something it cannot detect. Setting the diagnostic aside does not establish that citizens are competent; it only removes one central piece of evidence that they are not. Nonetheless, we have been judging citizens by a standard that cannot support our judgment. Our judgment should wait until we adopt one that can.

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Online Appendix for "Don't Judge Citizens for Changing Their Opinions"

Appendix A: Tabular Models

Table A.1: OLS Models of Opinion Stability

	Germany		Netherlands		United States	
	Same Opinion	Same Side	Same Opinion	Same Side	Same Opinion	Same Side
Value-Consistent	0.034	0.045	0.022	0.033	0.053	0.051
	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.019)	(0.018)
Education	0.019	0.039	0.049	0.041	0.048	0.075
	(0.004)	(0.004)	(0.013)	(0.012)	(0.031)	(0.029)
Political Interest	0.001	0.012	−0.003	0.026	0.019	0.019
	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.012)	(0.011)	(0.025)	(0.023)
Age	0.001	0.001	0.000	0.000	0.001	0.001
	(0.000)	(0.000)	(0.000)	(0.000)	(0.001)	(0.001)
Acquiescence	−0.073	−0.046	−0.116	−0.060	−0.034	−0.053
	(0.011)	(0.011)	(0.029)	(0.025)	(0.076)	(0.073)
Num.Obs.	10 231 703	10 231 703	768 551	768 551	11 160	11 160
RMSE	0.49	0.45	0.48	0.41	0.49	0.46

Note: This model includes case and trend fixed effects. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight. Wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist in parentheses.

Table A.2: Logit Models of Opinion Stability

	Germany		Netherlands		United States	
	Same Opinion	Same Side	Same Opinion	Same Side	Same Opinion	Same Side
Value-Consistent	0.147	0.228	0.103	0.236	0.226	0.262
	(0.009)	(0.011)	(0.022)	(0.033)	(0.080)	(0.095)
Education	0.080	0.185	0.215	0.239	0.203	0.365
	(0.018)	(0.020)	(0.059)	(0.068)	(0.129)	(0.146)
Political Interest	0.004	0.055	−0.010	0.158	0.080	0.092
	(0.021)	(0.023)	(0.054)	(0.065)	(0.106)	(0.111)
Age	0.003	0.005	0.002	−0.002	0.005	0.004
	(0.000)	(0.000)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.003)	(0.003)
Acquiescence	−0.311	−0.219	−0.513	−0.395	−0.147	−0.255
	(0.048)	(0.051)	(0.130)	(0.142)	(0.319)	(0.353)
Num.Obs.	10 231 703	10 231 703	768 551	768 551	11 157	11 157
RMSE	0.49	0.45	0.48	0.41	0.49	0.46

Note: This model includes case and trend fixed effects. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight. Standard errors clustered by panelist in parentheses.

Appendix B: Identifying Value-Policy Pairs for Analysis

Before conducting the main analyses, I needed to identify which policy items in the panel datasets should relate to conservation and self-transcendence values. I did so through a systematic literature review.

On February 10, 2026, I searched Scopus for English-language journal articles published since 2010. Articles had to mention the following in their title, abstract, or keywords: *values;* some variation of *politics* or *policy;* and some variation of *attitude, belief, opinion,* or *preference.*[1] Additionally, the full text of the article had to name at least one Schwartz value of interest[2] and cite an author named Schwartz.

I then reviewed the abstract of each article—and the full article text in ambiguous cases—to identify those that quantitatively estimated the relationship between basic values and policy opinions within a broad sample. This yielded 24 articles. I supplemented these with 18 other articles that I already knew of or that were returned by a similar search of Google Scholar.

Next, I reviewed all 42 publications in full, recording the direction and significance of reported associations between values and policy opinions, along with descriptions of the policy types underlying each association. Importantly, some studies reported effects for higher-order values (e.g., conservation) and the lower-order values that constitute them (e.g., tradition, security). In these cases, I referred to the associations between higher-order values and policy opinions. Other studies only examined associations between lower-order values and policy opinions. In such cases, I inferred the effect for the higher-order value from its lower-order values, provided their effects did not significantly conflict. For example, if all three lower-order values of conservation (i.e., conformity, tradition, and security) were positively associated with a policy opinion—or if some were positive and others null—I considered conservation to have a positive association with that opinion. If there were significant, oppositely signed associations between the lower-order values and the opinion, I recorded the relationship as "mixed."

Finally, I identified which associations were consistent across studies and sub-groups of respondents. An association was consistent if, when statistically significant, it always pointed in the same direction. Null effects in some studies were acceptable, as they may reflect limited statistical power. But if, say, conservation values were positively associated with economic conservatism in one study or sub-group but negatively associated in another, the association was not considered consistent. The results of this process are presented in Table B.1. The "S.T." and "CON." columns indicate whether the value is generally associated with support for stereotypically left-wing opinions, right-wing opinions, or a mix of both.

[1] The exact query was *values AND (politic* OR polic*) AND (attitud* OR belief* OR opinion* OR preference*).*

[2] The exact query was *(self-transcendence OR conservation OR universalism OR benevolence OR conformity OR tradition OR security).*

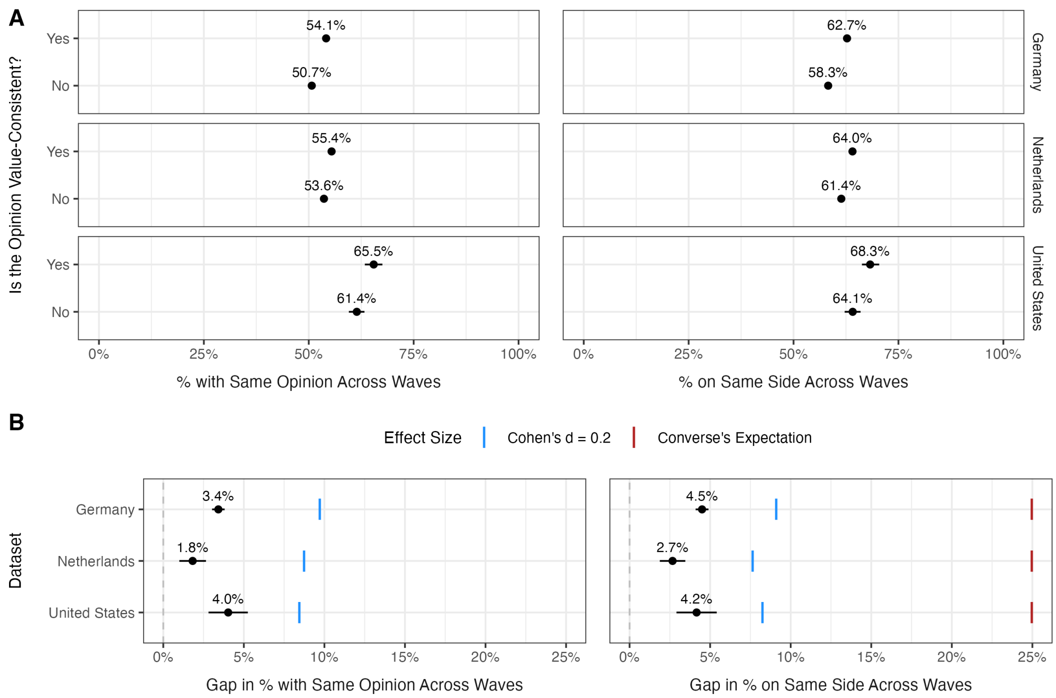
Table B.1: "Social" Values and Related Policy Opinions

Policy Area	**S.T.**	**CON.**	**Sources**
Welfare, redistribution, and free enterprise (e.g., higher taxes on the rich)	Left	Mixed	Abdallah (2023); Arikan and Sekercioglu (2019); Reinl et al. (2024); Schwartz, Caprara and Vecchione (2010); Schwartz et al. (2014); Wu and Molden (2024)
Environmental protection (e.g., CO_2 taxes)	Left	Right	Abdallah (2023); Bergquist et al. (2022); Davidov and Meuleman (2012); Grunert and Juhl (1995); Milfont and Gouveia (2006); Nilsson, von Borgstede and Biel (2004); Oh, Hudson and Hudson (2025); Perlaviciute and Steg (2015); Schwartz (2012); Smith and Hempel (2022); Steg, Dreijerink and Abrahamse (2005); Steg et al. (2011); Stern et al. (1995); Stern, Dietz and Guagnano (1998)
Immigration	Left	Right	Abdallah (2023); Ahmadinia (2025); Cichocki and Jabkowski (2019); Davidov et al. (2008); Dennison, Davidov and Seddig (2020); Messing and Ságvári (2021); Miglietta, Tartaglia and Loera (2018); Schwartz (2007*b*); Schwartz (2007*a*); Schwartz, Caprara and Vecchione (2010); Schwartz et al. (2014); Seewann (2022)
International cooperation (e.g., EU membership)	Mixed	Mixed	Dennison, Seddig and Davidov (2021); Goren et al. (2016); Rathbun et al. (2016); Reinl et al. (2024)
Law, order, and civil liberties (e.g., limiting terrorism by restricting movement)	Left	Right	Schwartz, Caprara and Vecchione (2010); Schwartz et al. (2014)
Military interventions (e.g., defense spending)	Left	Right	Crawford, Wiley and Ventresco (2014); Goren et al. (2016); O'Dwyer and oymak (2020); Rathbun et al. (2016); Schwartz, Caprara and Vecchione (2010); Schwartz et al. (2014)
Nuclear power	Left	Right	Perlaviciute and Steg (2015); Whitfield et al. (2009)
Racial equality (e.g., aid to Black people)	Left	Right	Goren et al. (2016); Grigoryan and Schwartz (2021)
Social mores (e.g., gay marriage)	Mixed	Right	Abdallah (2023); Dobewall and Rudnev (2014); Donaldson, Handren and Lac (2017); Goren et al. (2016); Kuntz et al. (2015); Schwartz, Caprara and Vecchione (2010); Schwartz (2012); Schwartz et al. (2014); Wu and Molden (2024)

Appendix C: Results When Including Shorter Scales

The main analyses use only five- to seven-point Likert items for comparability. Here, I extend the analysis to all relevant policy items, including binary ones. As shown in Figure C.1, results closely mirror those in the main paper.

Figure C.1: Results When Using All Policy Items



Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B compares the gap with Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's historical 25-point citizen–legislator contrast. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data are weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Appendix D: Results When Empirically Defining Value-Policy Alignment

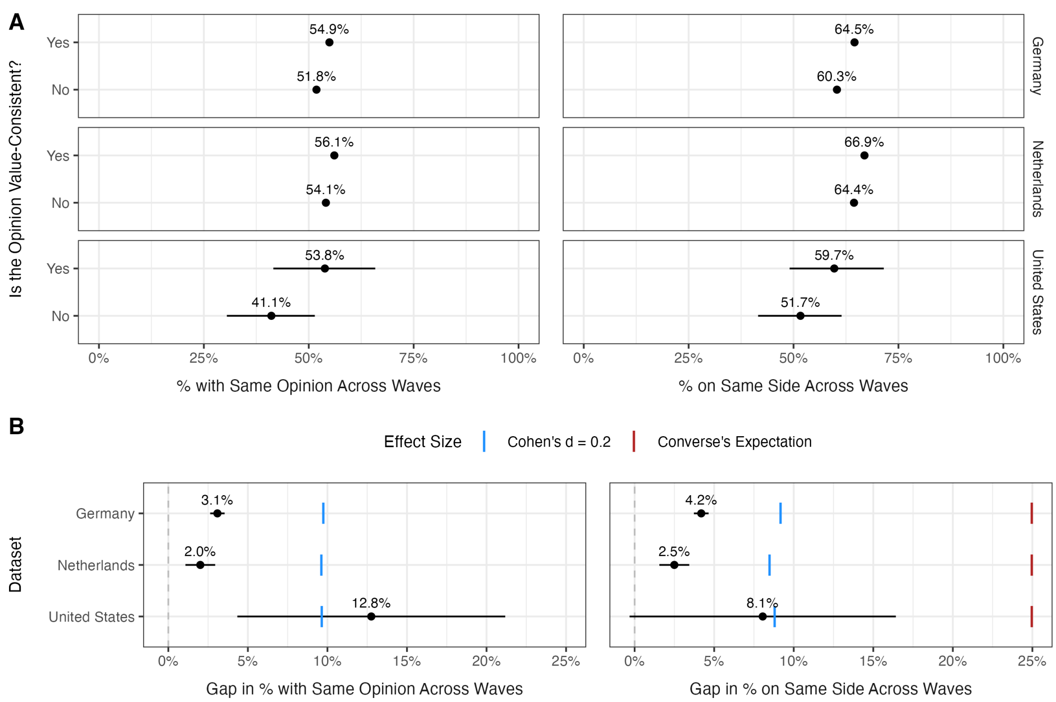
The main analyses rely on a literature-derived mapping of values to policy opinions, which may involve contestable judgment calls. As an alternative, I replicated the analyses using a purely empirical approach. For each policy opinion, I estimated the following regression:

$$Opinion_{i,t} = \beta_1 * SelfTranscendence_i + \beta_2 * Conservation_i + \beta_3 * Acquiescence + \delta_t + \epsilon$$

Here, $Opinion$ is panelist i's position on the issue at wave t, $SelfTranscendence$ and $Conservation$ capture endorsement of each value dimension, $Acquiescence$ controls for indiscriminate agreement with value statements, and δ_t represents wave fixed effects. I adjusted for multiple comparisons using the Holm (1979) method ($p < .05$). If a value had a significant effect on a policy opinion, after adjusting for multiple comparisons, the direction of that effect dictated the "proper" direction of the association.

Figure D.1 presents these results, which broadly match the main findings. The U.S. estimates grow noisier under this specification but remain consistent with a small effect.

Figure D.1: Results When Empirically Defining Value-Policy Alignment



Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B compares the gap with Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's historical 25-point citizen–legislator contrast. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data are weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Appendix E: Modeling Case-Wise Heterogeneity

To assess whether the association between value-consistency and stability varies by value or policy issue, I estimate a separate OLS regression for each value-policy pairing:

$$OpinionStable_{i,t} = \beta_1 * ValueConsistent_{i,t} + \beta * Traits_{i,t} + \delta_{s,t} + \epsilon$$

Here, $OpinionStable$ equals one if panelist i's opinion remained on the same side of the issue over period t, and $ValueConsistent$ equals one if the opinion aligned with the relevant value at the period's start. $Traits$ includes education, political interest, age, and—following convention in values research—acquiescence (Schwartz 1992). "Trend" fixed effects (δ) absorb variation due to the initial stance held on a policy issue (e.g., left, center, or right). Figure 3 in the main paper visualizes the results of these models.

Appendix F: Does Time Affect the Stability Gap?

Longer gaps between waves might erode opinion stability or widen the gap between value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. To test this, I estimated the following OLS regression for each panel:

$$OpinionStable_{i,p,t} = \beta_1 * ValueConsistent_{i,p,v,t} + \beta_2 * YearsElapsed_{i,p,t} + \beta_3 * ValueConsistent_{i,p,v,t} * YearsElapsed_{i,p,t} + \alpha_{p,v} + \delta_{s,p} + \epsilon$$

The dependent variable, *OpinionStable*, equals one if panelist i held the same position on policy issue p across period t. $ValueConsistent$ flags whether that opinion aligned with value v at the period's start, and $YearsElapsed$ measures the period's duration in years.

Two sets of fixed effects address unobserved heterogeneity. "Case" fixed effects (α) restrict comparisons to within a given value-policy pairing. "Trend" fixed effects (δ) absorb differences tied to the initial stance on an issue (e.g., left, center, or right), since some positions—such as moderate ones—may be inherently less stable.

As shown in the table below, longer inter-wave gaps slightly reduce average opinion stability, but they do not widen the consistency-stability gap.

Table F.1: Does Period Length Affect the Stability Gap?

	Germany		Netherlands		United States	
	Same Opinion	Same Side	Same Opinion	Same Side	Same Opinion	Same Side
Value-Consistent	0.033	0.039	0.022	0.027	0.042	0.058
	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.018)	(0.018)
Years Between Waves	-0.017	-0.017	-0.008	-0.006	-0.022	-0.014
	(0.090)	(0.092)	(0.061)	(0.056)	(0.066)	(0.059)
Interaction	0.000	0.003	0.001	0.002	0.005	-0.001
	(0.182)	(0.184)	(0.101)	(0.093)	(0.126)	(0.131)
Num.Obs.	10231703	10231703	662936	662936	11160	11160
RMSE	0.49	0.45	0.48	0.41	0.49	0.46

Note: This model includes case and policy-stance fixed effects. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight. Wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist in parentheses.

Appendix G: Stability of Political Values vs. Policy Opinions

Scholars question whether political values are distinct from, or exogenous to, policy opinions (Arceneaux et al. 2025). Rather than shaping policy opinions, these values may simply summarize citizens' views within a particular domain.

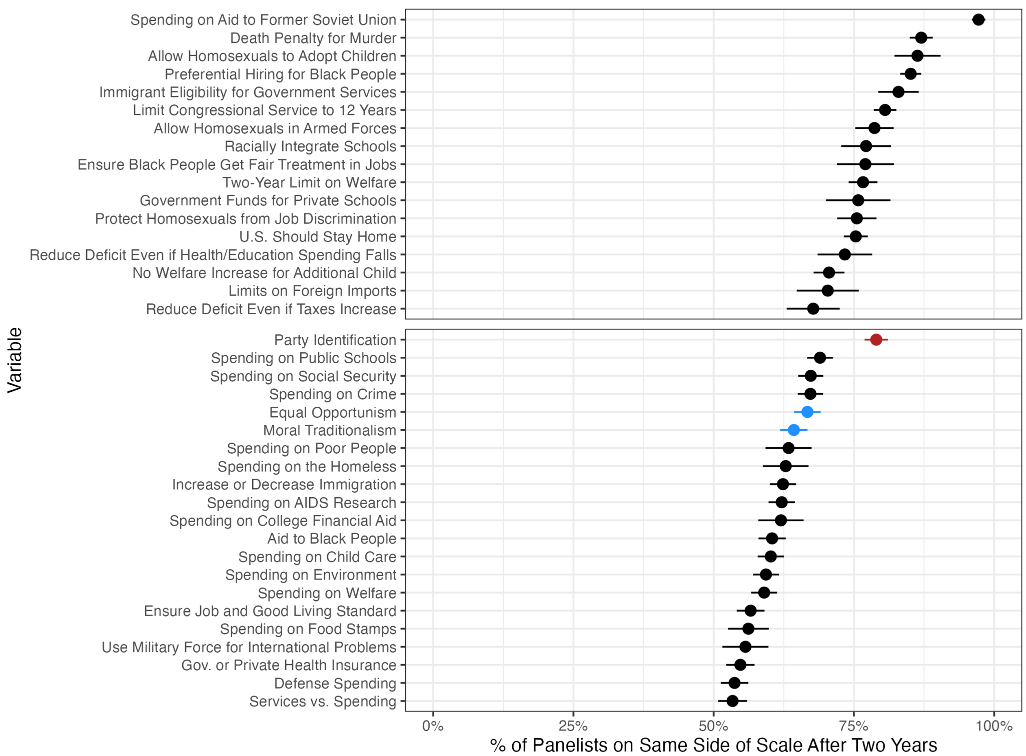
To investigate, I drew on the 1992–96 and 2016–24 panels from the American National Election Study (American National Election Studies 1999, 2025). All variables were trisected (left-wing, scale midpoint, right-wing) to ensure comparability, and the data were restructured so each row represents panelist i's score on variable v at the beginning and end of period t. I then estimated this OLS regression for each dataset:

$$Stable_{i,v,t} = \beta * Variable_v + \delta_t + \epsilon$$

$Stable$ equals one if panelist i stood on the same side of variable v across period t; $Variable$ is a factor identifying the variable; and δ captures period fixed effects.

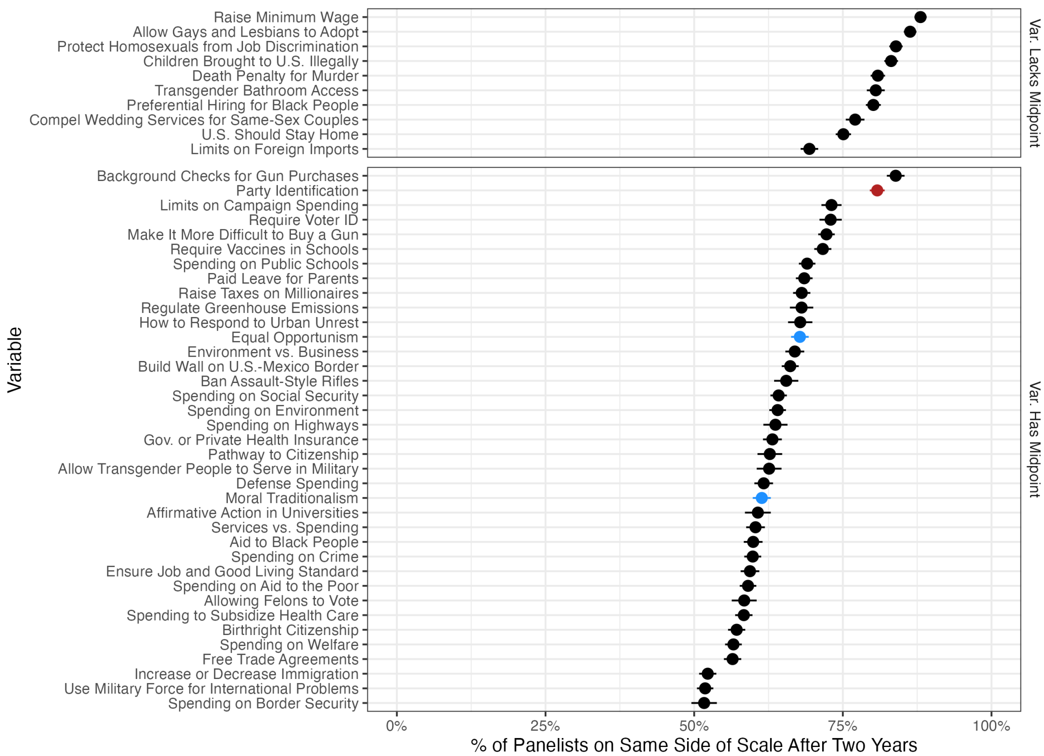
Figure G.1 and Figure G.2 display the predicted stability of each variable, revealing that political values are roughly as unstable as policy opinions.

Figure G.1: Stability of Political Values vs. Policy Opinions (ANES 1992–96 Panel)



Note: Predicted stability of variables in the ANES 1992–96 panel. Blue points represent political value indexes; black points represent policy opinions; and red points represent party identification. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from standard errors clustered by panelist.

Figure G.2: Stability of Political Values vs. Policy Opinions (ANES 2016–24 Panel)



Note: Predicted stability of variables in the ANES 2016–24 panel. Blue points represent political value indexes; black points represent policy opinions; and red points represent party identification. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from standard errors clustered by panelist.

Appendix H: Stability of Basic Values vs. Policy Opinions

A separate German panel—the Leibniz Institute for the Social Sciences (GESIS) panel—allows a direct comparison of the stability of basic values and policy opinions (GESIS 2025). It measured 6,165 panelists' basic values across ten waves and also contains repeated measures of 31 policy opinions.

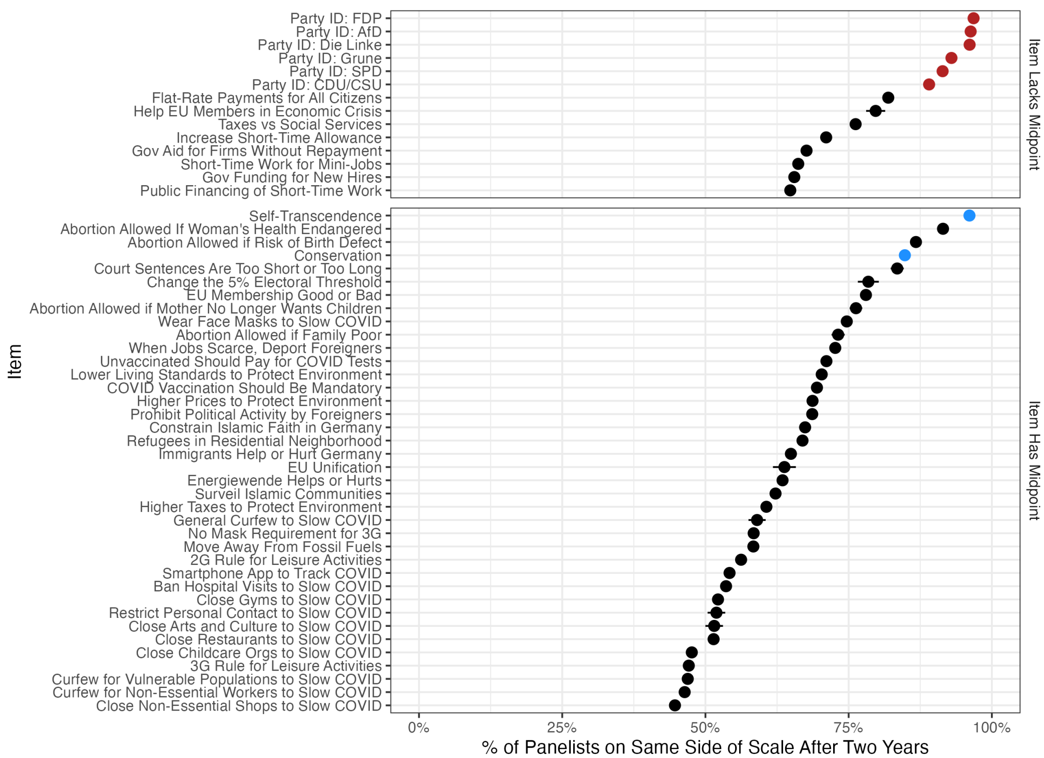
All variables were trisected (left-wing, scale midpoint, right-wing) to ensure comparability, and the data were restructured so each row represents panelist i's score on variable v at the beginning and end of period t. I then estimated:

$$Stable_{i,v,t} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 * Years_t + \beta * Variable_v + \epsilon$$

Stable is defined as before; $Years$ captures the period length; and $Variable$ identifies the variable. I do not use period fixed effects in this model because of insufficient overlap in variables across waves.

Figure H.1 displays the results. In a typical year, 97% and 86% of panelists remained stable on self-transcendence and conservation values, respectively. Most policy opinions were far less stable (*Average Stability = 66%*). Only two policy opinions showed more stability than conservation values.

Figure H.1: Stability of Basic Values vs. Policy Opinions



Note: Predicted stability of variables in the GESIS Panel. Blue points represent basic value indexes; black points represent policy opinions; and red points represent party identification. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from standard errors clustered by panelist.

Appendix I: Value-Policy Correlations Over Time

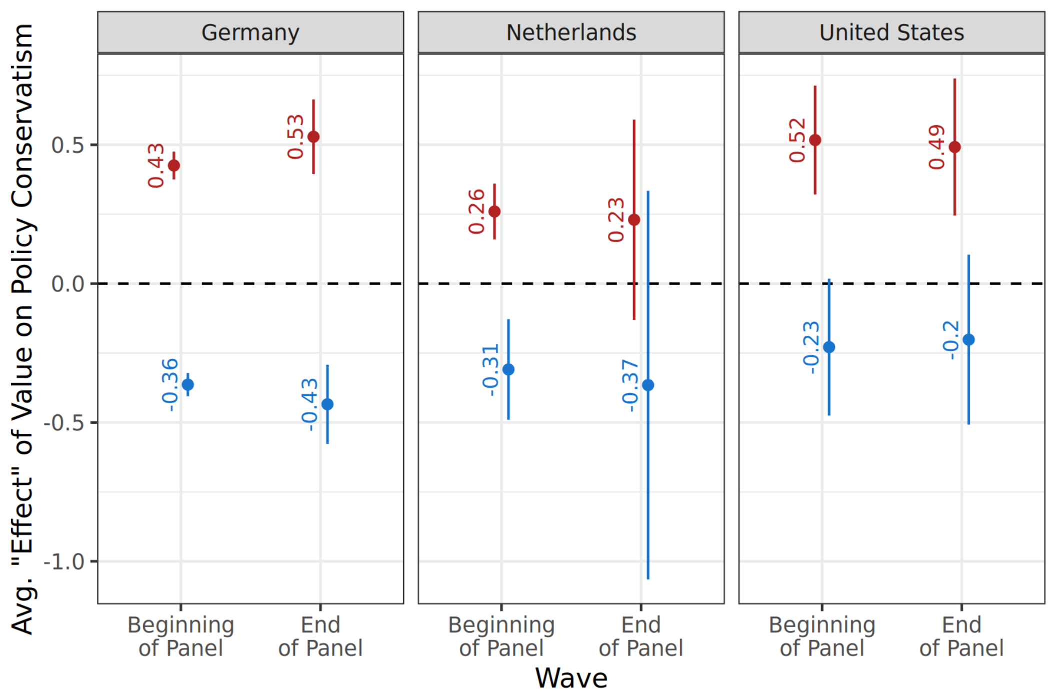
Each panel in the main analysis measures values once—at the start (Germany, Netherlands) or end (United States)—so I cannot directly verify that values remained stable throughout. I can, however, test an implication of value change: If values shifted, their average cross-sectional association with related policy opinions should weaken as the measurement grows stale. Individual value-policy correlations may increase or decrease with changing circumstances, but an average across many opinions should predominantly reflect the passage of time. For each value and panel, I estimated:

$$Policy_{i,p,t} = \beta_1 * Value_i + \beta_2 * Years_{i,p,t} + \beta_3 * Acquiescence_i +$$
$$\beta_4 * Value_i * Years_{i,p,t} + \beta_5 * Years_{i,p,t} * Acquiescence_i + \beta_6 * Value_i * Acquiescence_i$$
$$+\beta_7 * Value_i * Years_{i,p,t} * Acquiescence_i + \gamma_p + \varepsilon_{i,p,t}$$

Policy is panelist i's opinion on issue p at wave t; *Value* captures endorsement of the related value; *Years* is the gap (in years) between the value and policy measurements; *Acquiescence* controls for indiscriminate agreement with value statements; and γ denotes policy-issue fixed effects. I utilize a complete-interaction model to minimize bias in my estimates (Blackwell and Olson 2022).

Figure I.1 displays the associational "effect" of panelists' values on their policy opinions at the beginning and end of each panel. These effects change very little, though each panel spans many years. Indeed, if anything, the effects of values tend to grow with time. Notably, standard errors grow as the time between value and policy measurements increases. However, this is primarily a function of sample attrition: The number of observations decreases in later waves, naturally increasing the standard errors. Crucially, the point estimates remain stable across all waves. If true value change were occurring, we would expect the coefficients to decay toward zero; instead, they remain constant despite the reduced statistical power. Additionally, if value change were the culprit, the standard errors for middle-aged panelists—the group with the most stable values (Milfont, Milojev and Sibley 2016)—should stay relatively flat or grow much more slowly than the rest of the sample. Their standard errors grow even faster, suggesting that the noise has nothing to do with shifting values.

Figure I.1: Associational “Effect” of Values on Policy Conservatism by Time

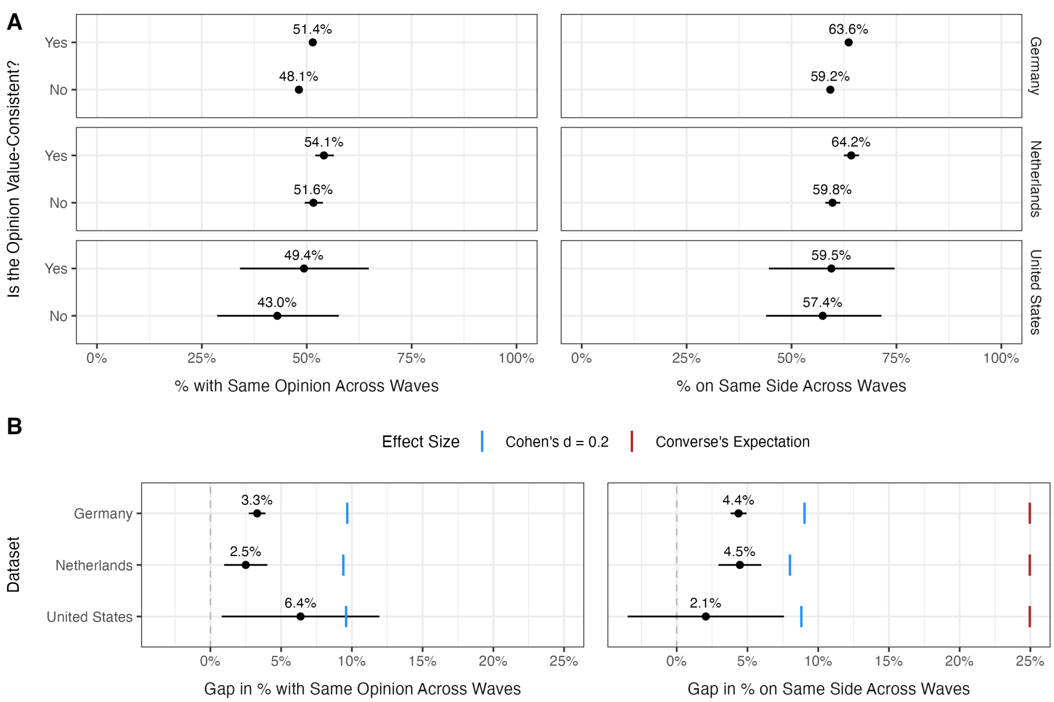


Note: Associational “effect’’ of panelists’ values on policy conservatism at the beginning and end of each panel. Blue points represent the effects of self-transcendence values; red points represent the effects of conservation values. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Appendix J: Results Among the Middle-Aged

If over-time value change were attenuating the estimates from my main analyses, restricting the sample to panelists with the most stable values should alter the results. Past research identifies 40- to 60-year-olds as the group least likely to shift their values (Milfont, Milojev and Sibley 2016). Figure J.1 confirms that results for this age group track the main findings closely. Point estimates in Figure J.1 resemble the full-sample estimates, though the U.S. coefficients become imprecise due to the smaller sample.

Figure J.1: Results Among Middle-Aged

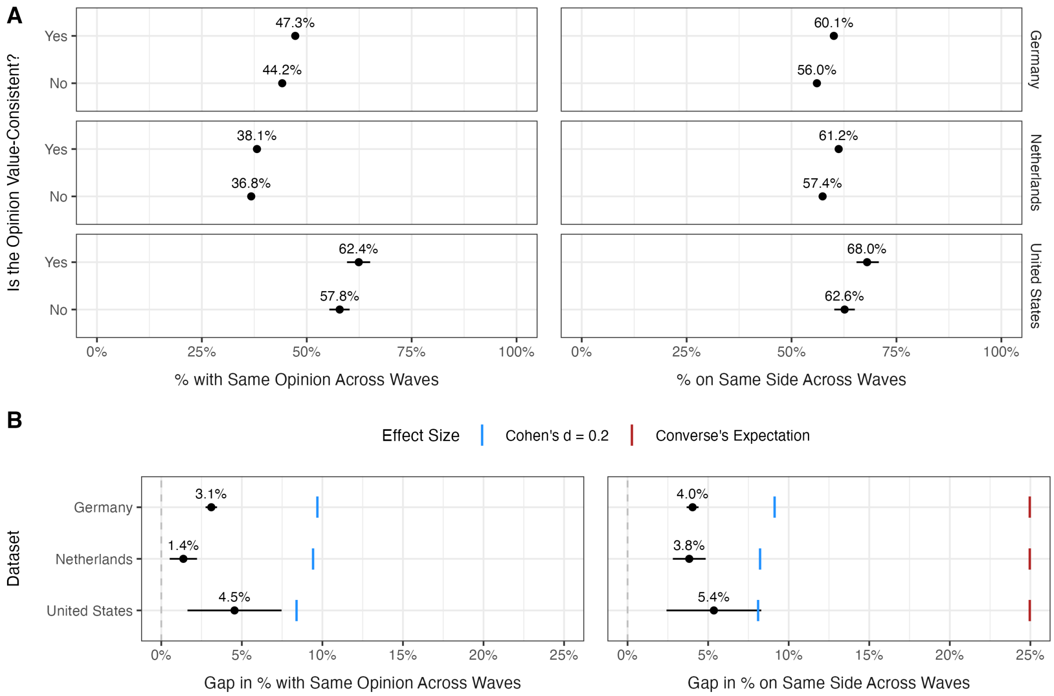


Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B compares the gap with Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's historical 25-point citizen–legislator contrast. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data are weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Appendix K: Results When Using Indexes of Policy Opinions

Measurement error in individual policy items could inflate instability. To guard against this, I replicated the analyses using policy-opinion indexes (Ansolabehere, Rodden and Snyder 2008). Within each panel dataset, I identified pairs of policy opinions that were measured on the same waves, conceptually related, and strongly correlated ($r < -.3$ *or* $r > .3$). This process yielded 22 indexes. Figure K.1 confirms that the results align with the main findings.

Figure K.1: Results When Using Indexes of Policy Opinions



Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B compares the gap with Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's historical 25-point citizen–legislator contrast. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data are weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Appendix L: Results When Using Continuous Measures

The main analyses rely on binary indicators of value-consistency and opinion stability. Binarization simplifies interpretation but may introduce measurement error, so I re-estimate the models using continuous alternatives. Value-consistency is measured as one minus the absolute distance between a panelist's value score and policy opinion (flipped so that they correlate positively). Opinion stability is similarly defined as one minus the absolute change in the panelist's opinion across waves.

The table below reports the results. The link between value-consistency and opinion stability remains modest. The United States shows the largest effect: Moving from the bottom to the top of the value-consistency scale cuts the average change in policy opinions by six percentage points. Put differently, a one-standard-deviation increase in value-consistency increases opinion stability by roughly 7% of a standard deviation.

Table L.1: Results Using Continuous Measures

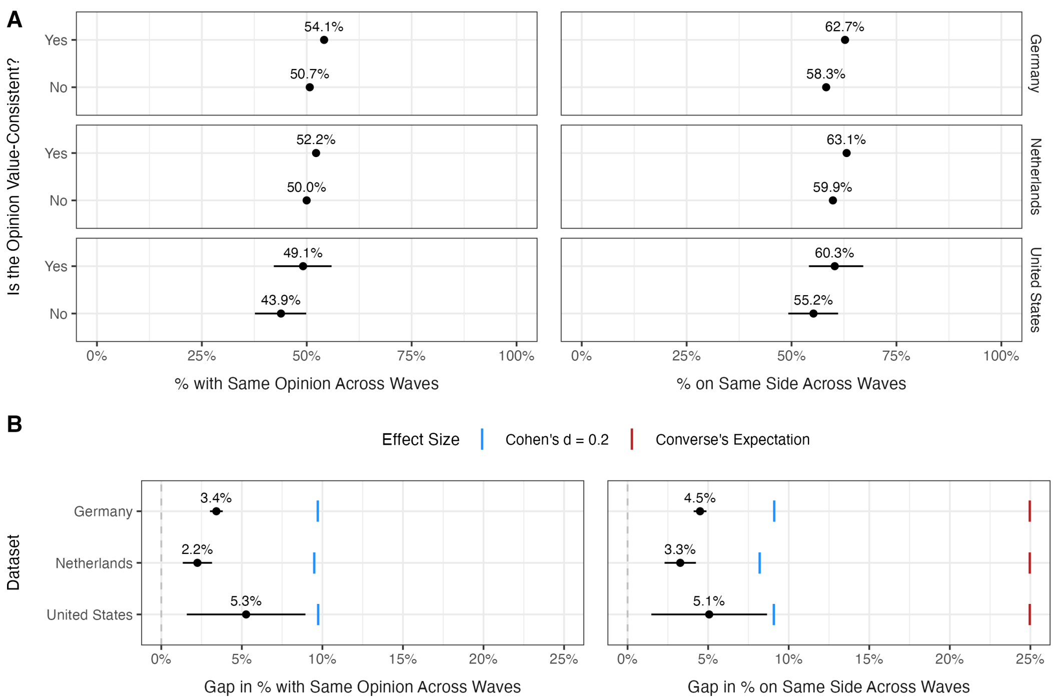
	Germany	Netherlands	United States
Value-Consistency	0.043	0.050	0.062
	(0.002)	(0.005)	(0.017)
Education	0.036	0.023	0.059
	(0.002)	(0.005)	(0.013)
Political Interest	0.000	0.000	0.013
	(0.002)	(0.005)	(0.011)
Age	0.000	0.000	0.000
	(0.000)	(0.000)	(0.000)
Acquiescence	−0.037	−0.037	−0.036
	(0.005)	(0.012)	(0.040)
Num.Obs.	10 438 870	769 773	11 334
RMSE	0.18	0.16	0.21

Note: This model includes case and trend fixed effects. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight. Wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist in parentheses.

Appendix M: Results When Values Are Most Important

Conservation and self-transcendence may matter little to some respondents, potentially diluting the consistency-stability link. To address this, I first compute value importance following Schwartz et al. (2001): For each participant, I calculate the absolute distance between their self-transcendence and conservation ratings and their mean agreement across all values. I then re-run the main models restricted to the top third of respondents on this importance measure. Figure M.1 shows that limiting the sample in this way does not meaningfully change the results.

Figure M.1: Results Among Those Who Care Most About Values



Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B compares the gap with Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's historical 25-point citizen–legislator contrast. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data are weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Appendix N: Results for Strongest Value-Policy Cases

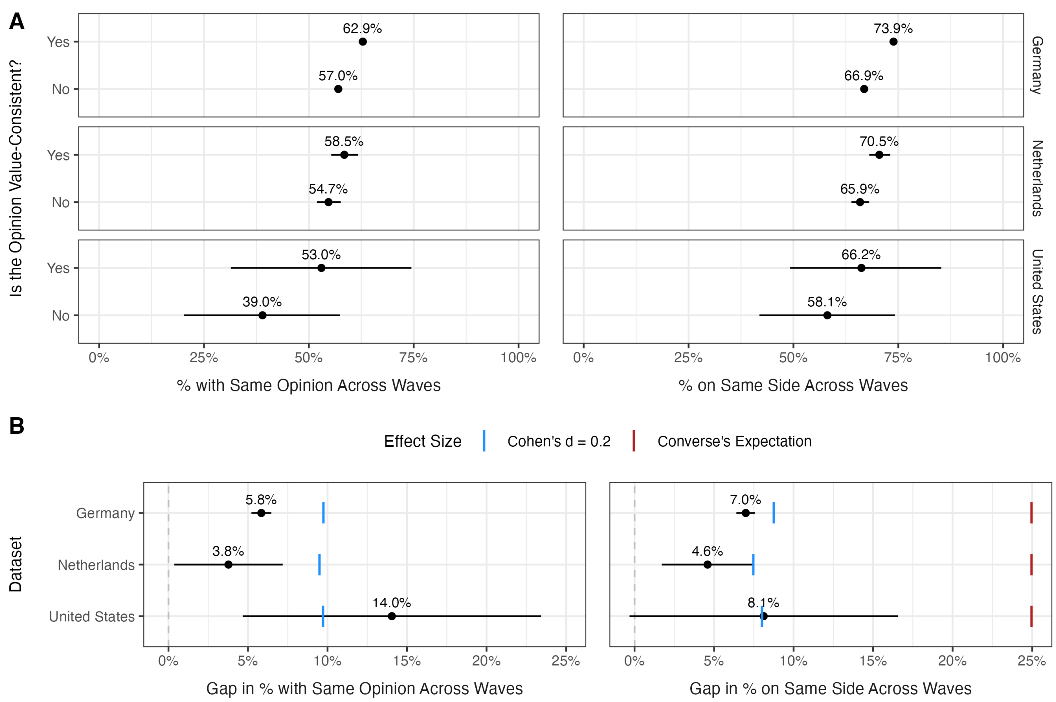
Perhaps the modest consistency-stability link reflects the fact that basic values are too distal from politics. If so, the link should be stronger among value-policy pairs with the tightest cross-sectional association. To identify such pairs, I estimated this OLS regression for each case and dataset:

$$Policy_{i,t} = \beta_1 * Value_i + \beta_2 * Acquiescence_i + \lambda_t + \epsilon_{i,t}$$

Policy is panelist i's position on a policy issue at wave t, collapsed to a three-point scale (left-wing, midpoint, right-wing). *Value* captures endorsement of the corresponding value. *Acquiescence* controls for the tendency to agree with all value statements regardless of content (Schwartz 1992). λ denotes wave fixed effects.

From these models, I identified those cases wherein the cross-sectional association between a value and policy opinion was robust (standardized coefficient $\geq .3$). Restricting the consistency-stability analysis to these strongly associated pairs yields Figure N.1. The pattern is consistent with the main findings, though U.S. estimates lose precision—without, however, becoming statistically distinguishable from a small effect.

Figure N.1: Results for Strongest Value-Policy Cases



Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B compares the gap with Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's historical 25-point citizen–legislator contrast. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data are weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Appendix O: Results Among Educated, Interested, and Knowledgeable Participants

Stability may discriminate consistent from inconsistent opinions more successfully among citizens with greater resources for connecting goals to policy means (Zaller 1992). This is a scope condition for the diagnostic relationship, not a requirement that representational consistency arise through deliberate value reasoning.

Direct measures of political knowledge are unevenly available across the panels: The Dutch panel contains no factual political-knowledge items, and the U.S. panel's only knowledge measure is a vocabulary test without political content. The German panel, however, includes a short factual battery in exactly the waves that measure basic values; I use it directly at the end of this section. Elsewhere, I proxy political knowledge with education and political interest (Delli Carpini and Keeter 1996). To validate these proxies, I estimated the following regression for each value, moderator, and panel:

$$Policy_{i,p,t} = \beta_1 * Value_i + \beta_2 * Moderator_{i,t} + \beta_3 * Acquiescence+$$
$$\beta_4 * Value_i * Moderator_{i,t} + \beta_5 * Moderator_{i,t} * Acquiescence_i + \beta_6 * Value_i * Acquiescence_i$$
$$+\beta_7 * Value_i * Moderator_{i,t} * Acquiescence_i + \gamma_p + \lambda_t + \varepsilon_{i,p,t}$$

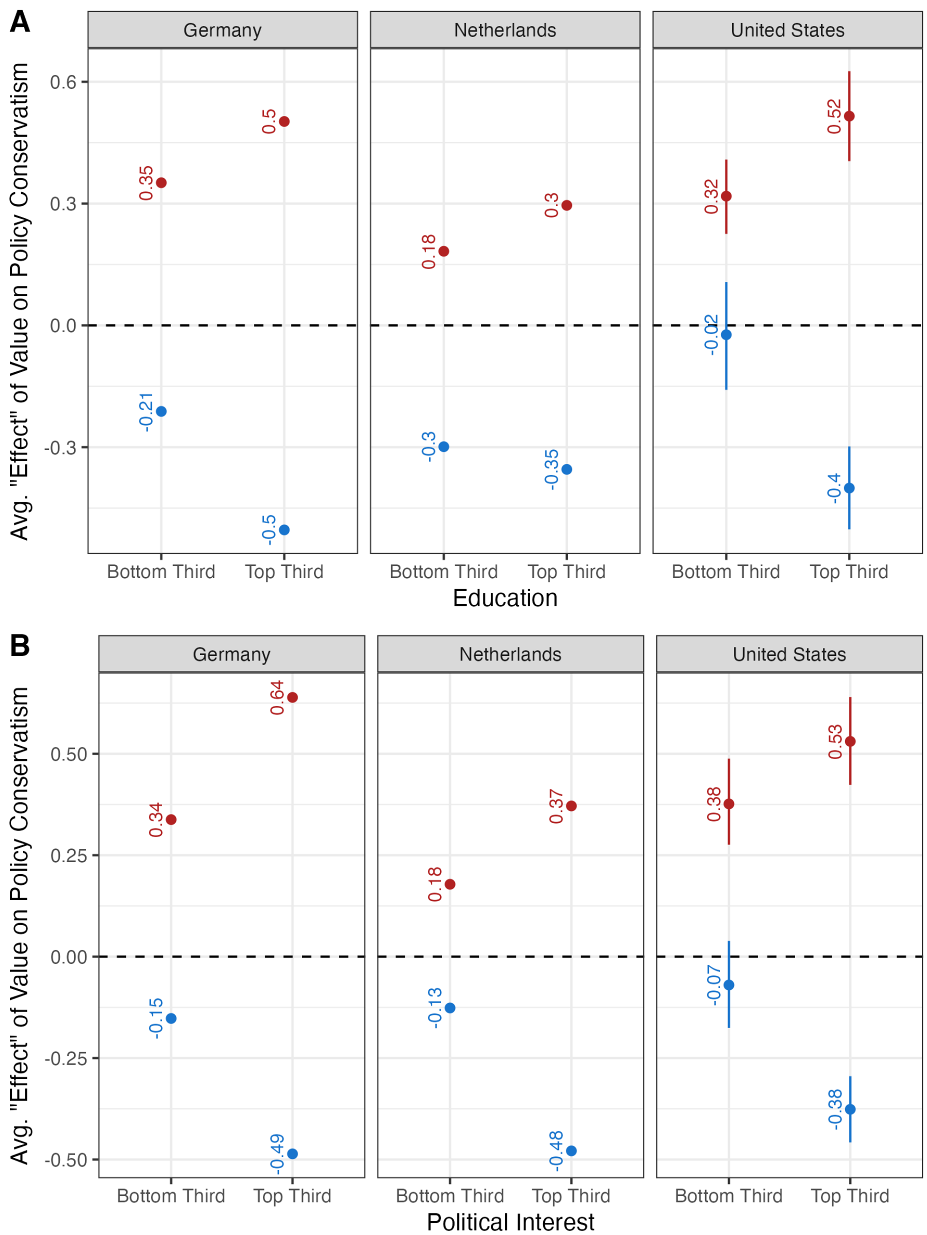
Policy is panelist i's opinion on issue p at wave t; $Value$ captures endorsement of the related value; and *Acquiescence* controls for indiscriminate agreement with value statements. $Moderator$ is education, political interest, or political knowledge measured at the wave level. The models include policy-issue (γ) and wave (λ) fixed effects and are fully interacted to minimize bias (Blackwell and Olson 2022).

Figure O.1 confirms that the associational "effects" of values on policy conservatism are larger when a panelist has more education or greater political interest. In short, the more educated and politically engaged more tightly connect values to policy opinions.

With these proxies validated, I replicate my main analyses within each high-sophistication group. Point estimates in Figure O.2 and Figure O.3 track the full-sample results, with the U.S. estimates losing precision.

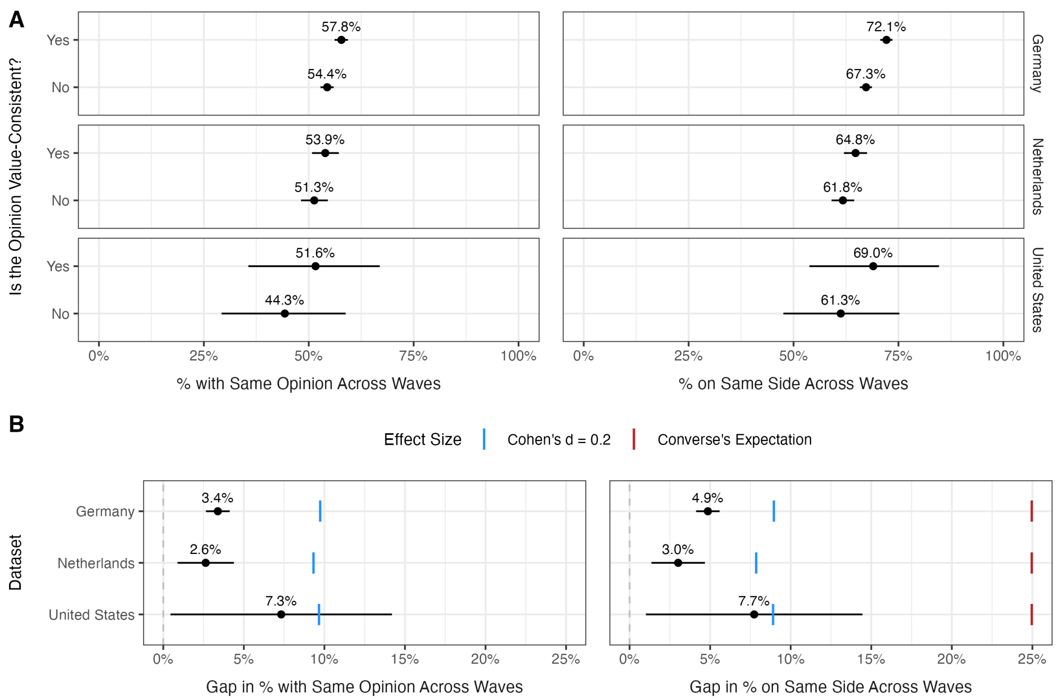
Finally, I use the German panel's factual-knowledge battery directly. Sixteen items cover the electoral system (the five-percent electoral threshold, the first and second votes (*Erststimme/Zweitstimme*), and the election of the Chancellor), the current unemployment rate, and the party affiliations of twelve prominent politicians. I score the items against the survey's correct-answer codes, treating "don't know" responses as incorrect, and average each panelist's most recent responses into an index from 0 to 1 ($n \approx 27,000$ panelists overlap with the value measures). Replicating the German comparison among observations in the top third of this index yields the same qualitative conclusion as the education and interest comparisons (Figure O.4): The stability gap remains small.

Figure O.1: Associational "Effect" of Values on Policy Conservatism by Education and Political Interest



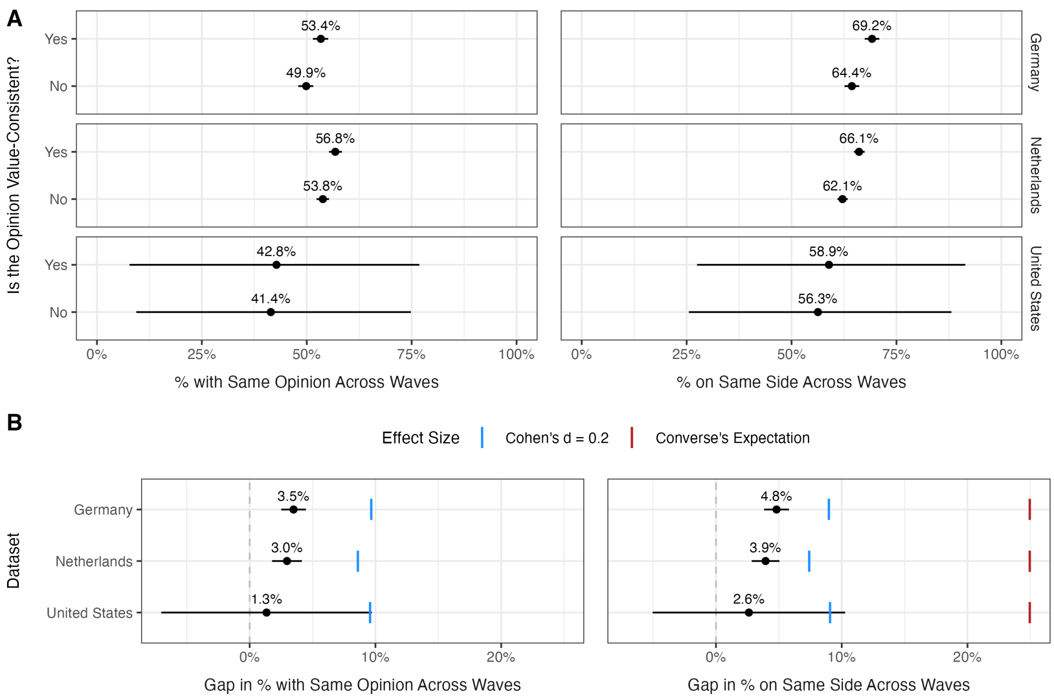
Note: Sub-figure A (B) depicts the associational "effect" of panelists' values on policy conservatism at different levels of education (political interest). Blue points represent the effects of self-transcendence values; red points represent the effects of conservation values. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data weighted to give each panelist, policy issue, and period equal weight.

Figure O.2: Results Among the Most Educated



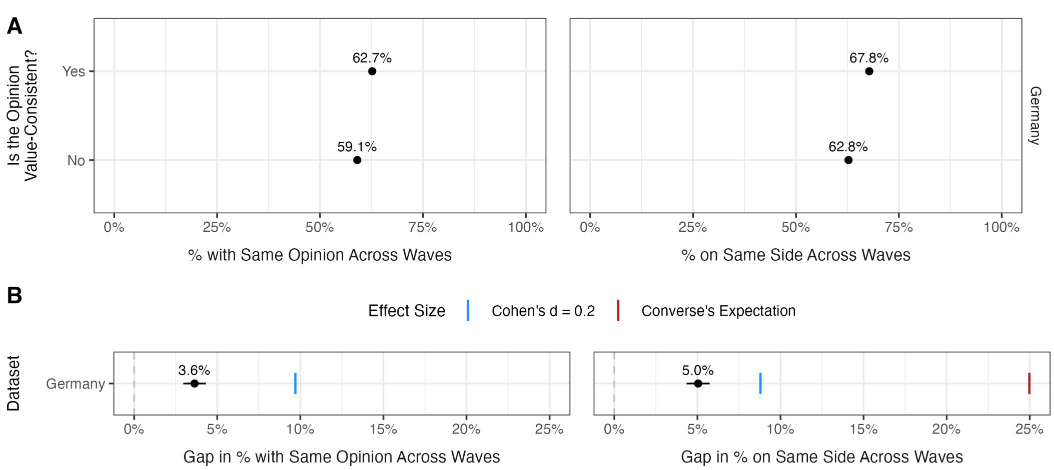
Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B compares the gap with Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's historical 25-point citizen–legislator contrast. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data are weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Figure O.3: Results Among the Most Politically Interested



Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B compares the gap with Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's historical 25-point citizen–legislator contrast. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data are weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Figure O.4: Results Among the Most Politically Knowledgeable



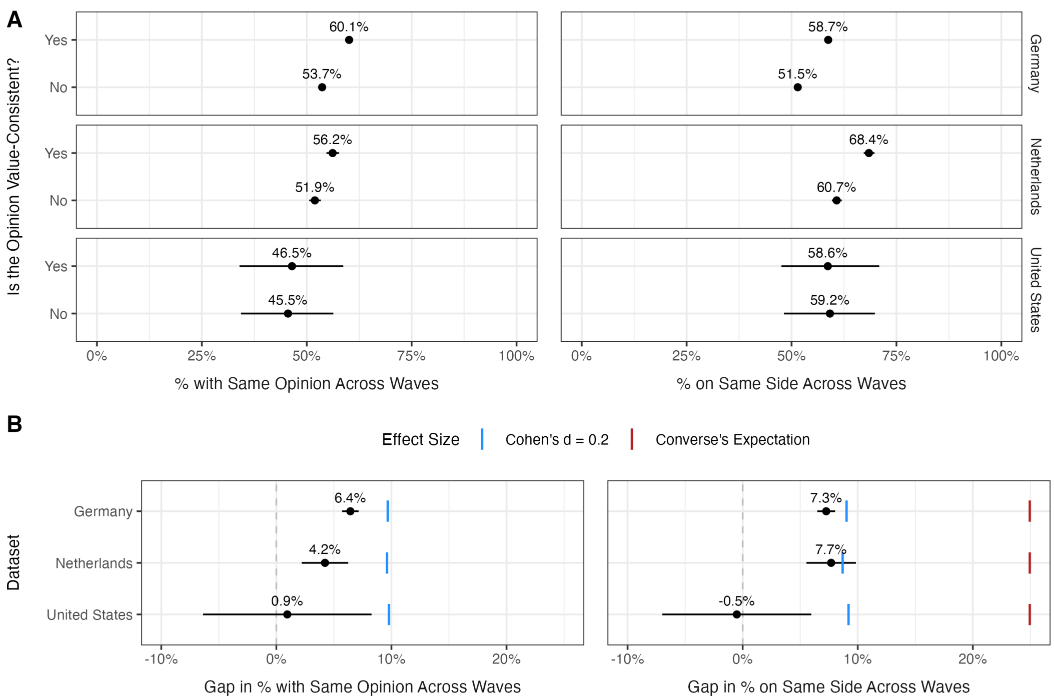
Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B compares the gap with Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's historical 25-point citizen–legislator contrast. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data are weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Appendix P: Results When Issues Implicate Both Values

The main analyses code value-consistency against one value at a time, so an opinion coded as inconsistent with, say, self-transcendence may still advance the respondent's conservation values. To address this, I re-estimate the models on the subset of policy issues that the literature ties to *both* self-transcendence and conservation values (see Table B.1 in Appendix B). For these issues, the two values push in opposite directions: Self-transcendence predicts the left-wing position, and conservation predicts the right-wing position. I therefore identify which of the two values each panelist prioritizes—the difference between their conservation and self-transcendence scores—and code an opinion as value-consistent when it falls on the side of the issue associated with the prioritized value. Each issue enters the analysis once, and panelists who endorse both values equally are excluded. I then re-estimate the main models with this recoded consistency measure, retaining the same covariates, fixed effects, weights, and bootstrapped standard errors.

Figure P.1 shows that accounting for both values simultaneously does not change my conclusions. The consistency-stability gap is indistinguishable from zero in the United States. While statistically significant in Germany and the Netherlands, this gap remains below the Cohen's $d = 0.2$ benchmark in every panel—and far below Converse's expectation.

Figure P.1: Results When Issues Implicate Both Values



Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B compares the gap with Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's historical 25-point citizen–legislator contrast. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data are weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Appendix Q: Research Ethics and Data Availability

This appendix takes up two matters: the ethics of this research, which I assess against the American Political Science Association's *Principles and Guidance for Human Subjects Research* (2020), and the constraints that prevent the free public posting of some of the data analyzed in this article. I address each in turn.

Research Ethics

This article reports only secondary analyses of panel data collected by others: the German Longitudinal Election Study (GLES; GLES 2023), the Longitudinal Internet Studies for the Social Sciences (LISS; Scherpenzeel and Das 2010), and the General Social Survey's 2008–2012 panel (Smith, Marsden and Hout 2013) in the main text, plus the American National Election Study's 1992–96 and 2016–24 panels (American National Election Studies 1999, 2025) and the GESIS Panel (GESIS 2025) in this online appendix. I collected no original data and neither interacted nor intervened with any human participant.

The ethical obligations of data collection—recruitment, consent, and compensation—therefore fell to the organizations that produced each dataset, and each met them under its own documented protocols: Each panel recruited its members voluntarily, obtained their informed consent, and compensated them under its standard incentive scheme. Neither this study nor the value and policy measures it analyzes involved deception.

Confidentiality poses little difficulty here. I accessed only de-identified data, distributed by each provider for scientific use. I report results only in aggregate, and I made no attempt to re-identify any respondent. Because my findings concern population-level relationships between values and policy opinions—not any individual or group—the analyses pose no foreseeable risk to panelists beyond those the original collections already addressed.

Because the study is confined to secondary analyses of pre-existing, de-identified data, it required no review by an ethics board under the regulations applicable at my institution. The research complies with APSA's *Principles and Guidance for Human Subjects Research*.

Data Availability

Upon acceptance, I will deposit a replication archive in the journal's Dataverse. The archive will contain all code needed to reproduce every result in the article and this appendix from the raw data files, the complete question wordings (reproduced in the Replication Materials), and the exact version and identifier of each dataset. It will also include the raw data for the U.S. datasets—the GSS 2008–2012 panel and the ANES merged files—which are freely downloadable and whose terms permit redistribution.

What the archive cannot include is the raw data for the European panels: the GLES, the LISS, and the GESIS Panel. The obstacles are legal, not ethical or methodological. Legally, I accessed these data under scientific-use agreements that permit analysis but prohibit republication of person-level records. In practice, these constraints are narrow. Each European panel is available at no monetary cost, and access requires, at most, a free registration and agreement to standard scientific-use terms (see Table Q.1). No route is limited by institutional affiliation or country of residence. The GLES and GESIS Panel data are distributed through the GESIS data archive (https://search.gesis.org), and the LISS data through Centerdata (https://www.dataarchive.lissdata.nl). Together with the deposited code and U.S. data, these routes place every result in this article within reach of any researcher.

Table Q.1: Access Conditions for Datasets Used in This Article

Dataset	**Used In**	**Provider**	**Access**
GLES Panel (ZA6838)	Main text	GESIS – Leibniz Institute for the Social Sciences	Free download after registration and declaration of scientific use
LISS Panel	Main text	Centerdata, Tilburg University	Free for academic researchers after signing a data-use statement
GSS 2008–2012 Panel	Main text	NORC at the University of Chicago	Free direct download; no registration required
ANES 1992–96 and 2016–24 Merged Files	Appendix G	American National Election Studies	Free download after registration
GESIS Panel, Standard Edition (ZA5669)	Appendix H	GESIS – Leibniz Institute for the Social Sciences	Free by request after signing a data-use agreement

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